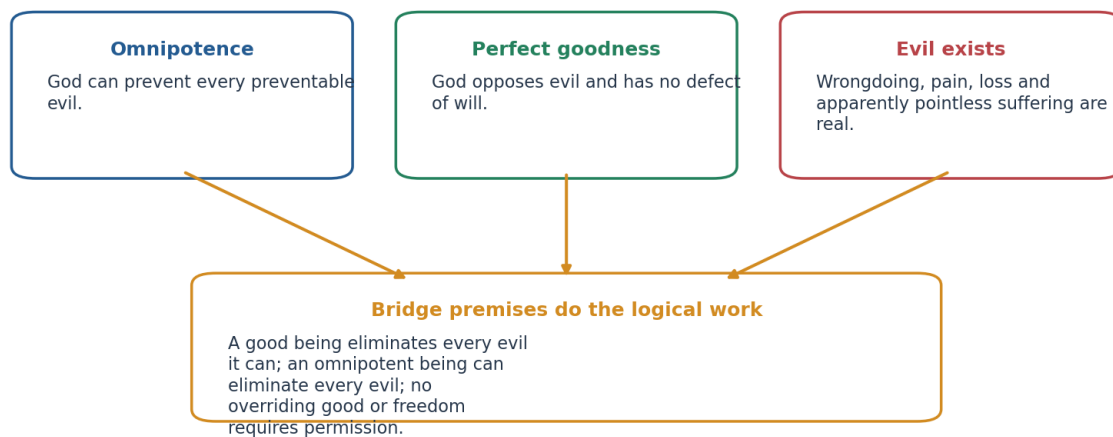


Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 03 - Problem of Evil

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

The classical pressure: an inconsistent set only with bridge premises



Mackie's challenge targets joint consistency, not any isolated divine attribute.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

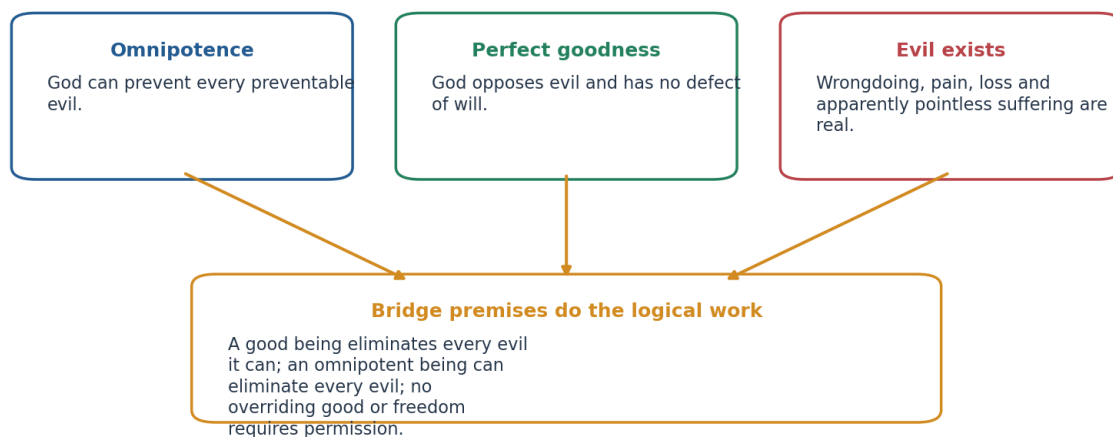
Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 03 - Problem of Evil

Complete learning-session package | Export date: 15 August 2026 | Approval: awaiting explicit approval

Syllabus owner: "Problem of Evil." **Method tags:** [THESIS] position; [ARGUMENT] reconstruction; [OBJECTION] strongest pressure; [REPLY] strongest answer; [QUALIFICATION] scope or source caution; [VERDICT] graded judgement. **Source order used:** audited repository Markdown and PYQ ledger; direct OCR extraction from John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, chapter 4, and local Indian-philosophy books; no live web was needed for doctrine or PYQ wording; Qdrant was not used. **Source limits:** local OCR contains damaged ligatures and diacritics. It was used to identify chapter structure and arguments, not to copy quotations. Exact PYQ wording is controlled by the audited 2018-2025 repository ledger. Epicurean attribution is stated cautiously because the familiar formulation is transmitted through later sources rather than a surviving text by Epicurus.

The classical pressure: an inconsistent set only with bridge premises



Mackie's challenge targets joint consistency, not any isolated divine attribute.

The inconsistent triad and its bridge premises

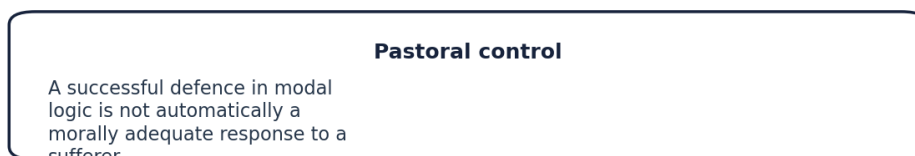
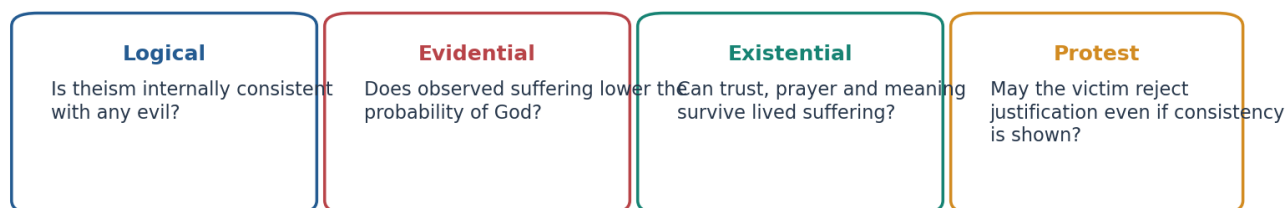
Roadmap

Session	Subtopic	Examiner task
1	Conceptual method	Separate logical, evidential, existential and protest problems
2	Classical logical problem	Reconstruct the triad, bridge premises and Mackie's target
3	Plantinga	Explain possible worlds, significant freedom and transworld depravity accurately
4	Evidential evil	Rowe, the fawn, noseeum inference, probability and skeptical theism
5	Classical theodicies	Augustine, Irenaeus-Hick, Leibniz, greater-good and natural-law approaches
6	Non-classical theisms	Process, finite and open models; identify the changed attribute
7	Existential protest	Job, Dostoevsky, Camus, horrendous evils and anti-theodicy
8	Indian frameworks	Karma-rebirth, Vedanta, Nyaya, Mimamsa, Samkhya, Buddhism and Jainism
9	Hard cases and synthesis	Animals, evolution, hiddenness, heaven, afterlife and moral costs
10	Exam conversion	Seven verified PYQs, drills, model answers and final register notes

PYQ priority: Very high. The audited Paper II corpus contains **7 primary-owned questions**, one in every year from 2019 through 2025 and none in 2018.

Session 1 - Conceptual Method: What Problem Is Being Asked?

Four problems that must not be collapsed



Compatibility, probability, meaning and moral protest are different philosophical tasks.

Logical, evidential, existential and protest taxonomy

1.1 The object of analysis

[THESIS] The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit. It becomes especially acute for classical creator-theism: an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good God creates and sustains a world containing apparently preventable evil.

[QUALIFICATION] Topic 01 owns detailed analysis of omnipotence, omniscience, goodness, eternity and God-world relations. Here those attributes are imported only as premises under stress. Topic 02 owns arguments for existence. Evil can rebut or undercut a proof, but this session does not repeat the proofs.

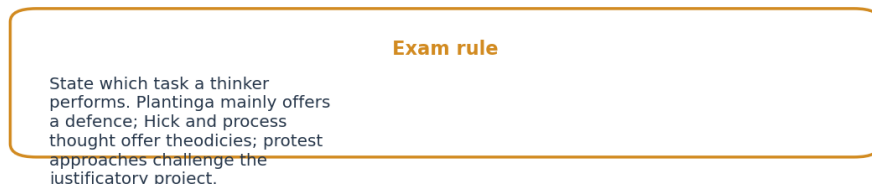
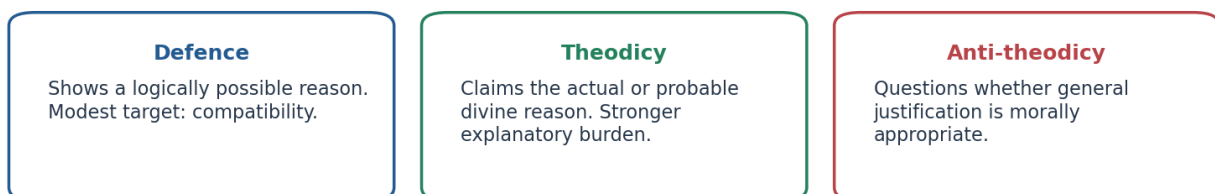
1.2 Four distinct challenges

1. **Logical challenge:** Is there a contradiction between God and the existence of any evil?
2. **Evidential challenge:** Even if compatibility is possible, does the observed amount, intensity and distribution of suffering make God improbable?
3. **Existential-religious challenge:** Can a person continue to trust, pray or find meaning when suffering is personally devastating?
4. **Pastoral or moral-protest challenge:** Is it ethically acceptable to justify another person's suffering as part of a cosmic plan?

[VERDICT] A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched. This is the master distinction of the topic.

1.3 Defence, theodicy, explanation and justification

Defence, theodicy and anti-theodicy



Do not praise a defence for explaining history or criticize it merely for declining to do so.

Defence, theodicy and anti-theodicy

Term	Exact burden	Typical example	Common mistake
Defence	Supplies a logically possible reason sufficient to block contradiction	Plantinga's Free Will Defence	Demanding that it prove God's actual motive
Theodicy	Claims to identify God's actual or probable morally sufficient reason	Hick's soul-making; process theodicy	Praising mere possibility as a historical explanation
Explanation	Gives a causal or structural account of why evil occurs	Free choice; natural law; karma	Assuming a cause morally justifies permission
Justification	Shows permission was morally right or at least non-culpable	Greater-good or freedom claim	Treating compensation as automatic justification
Anti-theodicy	Questions the morality or possibility of comprehensive justification	Dostoevskian protest; post-Holocaust caution	Confusing refusal to justify with denial of meaning or action

[THESIS] Compatibility is weaker than probability; probability is weaker than full explanation; explanation is different from moral justification. A high-scoring answer states which burden is being met.

1.4 Kinds of evil

Kinds of evil and the explanatory burden

Moral evil

Wrongdoing traceable to responsible agency: cruelty, betrayal, injustice.

Natural evil

Disease, earthquake, predation and pain not directly produced by a human choice.

Metaphysical evil

Finitude, vulnerability and limitation as features of created existence.

Do not equate evil and suffering

Wrongdoing can occur without immediate suffering; suffering can occur without wrongdoing. A theory must specify its target.

First-order harms may enable second-order goods, but enablement is not yet justification.

Moral, natural and metaphysical evil

- **Moral evil** consists in culpable wrongdoing by responsible agents.
- **Natural evil** consists in pain, disease, disaster and predation not directly attributable to a human choice.
- **Metaphysical evil** names finitude, limitation or imperfection as such. It does not follow that every limitation is morally evil.
- **Suffering** is an experiential harm; **wrongdoing** is a culpable act or disposition. Either can occur without the other.
- **First-order evils** are direct pains, losses and wrongs. **Second-order goods** such as courage, compassion and forgiveness arise in response to vulnerability. The availability of a second-order good does not by itself show that the first-order evil was necessary or proportionate.

[MEMORY] Four controls: **C-P-J-T** - Compatibility, Probability, Justification, Target.

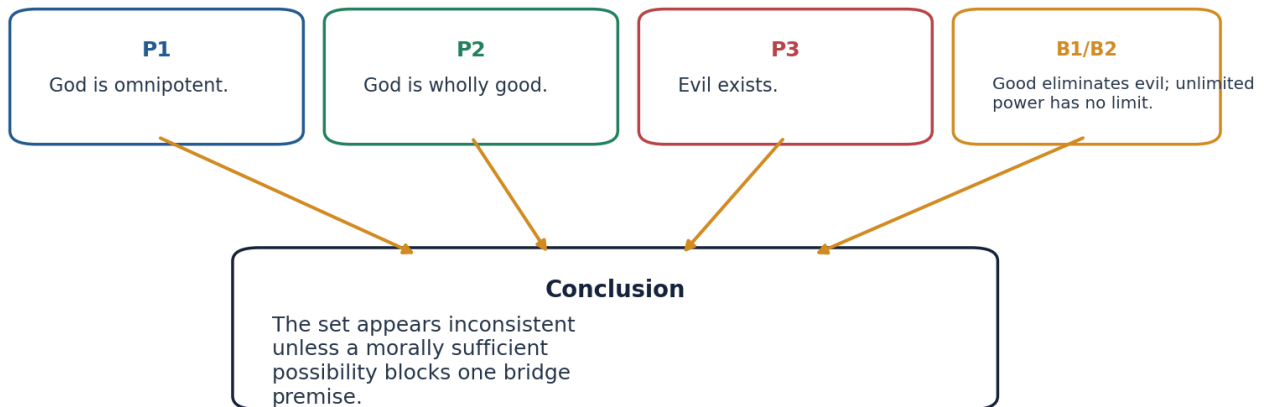
Session 2 - Classical Formulation and Mackie's Logical Problem

2.1 Epicurean attribution caution, Hume and Mackie

[QUALIFICATION] The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox. The exact popular wording should not be presented as a verbatim quotation from Epicurus. The dilemma is transmitted in later discussion, prominently through Lactantius, and Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* gives a celebrated modern formulation through Philo.

[THESIS] J. L. Mackie's 1955 essay "Evil and Omnipotence" turns the inherited dilemma into a logical charge against the simultaneous affirmation of omnipotence, complete goodness and evil.

Mackie's logical argument



A defence needs possibility; a theodicy claims the actual divine reason.

Mackie's logical argument

2.2 Formal reconstruction

[ARGUMENT]

1. God is omnipotent.
2. God is wholly good.
3. Evil exists.
4. A wholly good being eliminates evil as far as it can.
5. An omnipotent being has no relevant limit on eliminating evil.
6. Therefore, if such a God exists, evil should not exist.
7. Evil exists; hence the set appears inconsistent.

[QUALIFICATION] Premises 4 and 5 are not mere definitions. They require an account of logically possible action, morally sufficient reasons, freedom, stable laws and goods that may entail risk. The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.

2.3 What counts as a reply?

[THESIS] The theist need not show why every actual evil occurs in order to defeat a bare contradiction. It is enough to show a possible proposition consistent with God and evil, such as: God has a morally sufficient reason to permit some evil because significantly free creaturely agency is a great good that cannot be causally guaranteed.

[OBJECTION] This can look evasive: possibility is cheap, while actual horrors remain.

[REPLY] That objection changes the target from logical inconsistency to plausibility, evidence or moral adequacy. It is legitimate, but it must be named as a new stage.

2.4 Omnipotence paradox and attribute control

[THESIS] Omnipotence means power to do what is logically possible, not power to instantiate contradictions. God cannot make a free act both causally determined by God and libertarianly undetermined in the same respect.

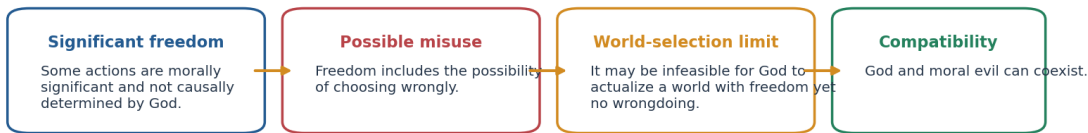
[OBJECTION] Restricting omnipotence to the logically possible may merely define away the problem.

[REPLY] Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power. Yet the critic can still ask why a logically possible, better feasible world was not actualized. That moves toward Plantinga's world-feasibility claim and then toward evidential comparison.

[VERDICT] Mackie's argument remains pedagogically decisive because it forces the theist to state the hidden moral and modal assumptions. Its original strict inconsistency charge is weaker once a coherent freedom-based possibility is admitted, but the evidential successor remains powerful.

Session 3 - Plantinga's Free Will Defence

Plantinga's Free Will Defence: modal compatibility, not a complete theodicy



Logical possibility defeats a charge of contradiction; it does not show the story is probable or actual.

Plantinga's Free Will Defence

3.1 Significant freedom and possible worlds

[THESIS] Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem. A person is significantly free with respect to an action when the action is morally significant and the person is free to perform or refrain from it. A world containing such agency may be more valuable than a world of determined conformity.

[ARGUMENT]

1. Significant freedom is a great good.
2. If God causally determines every significantly free choice to be right, the choice is not libertarianly free in relation to God.
3. It is possible that every world feasible for God that includes significantly free creatures also includes at least some wrongdoing.
4. If so, God's inability to actualize freedom-with-guaranteed-goodness is not lack of omnipotence, because the proposed object is not a feasible world God can strongly actualize.
5. Therefore God's existence is logically compatible with moral evil.

3.2 Transworld depravity accurately stated

[QUALIFICATION] **Transworld depravity** is not the claim that every person is maximally wicked or always chooses evil. It is a technical modal possibility: for any creaturely essence God might instantiate with significant freedom, in every feasible world where that essence is significantly free, it goes wrong in at least one relevant circumstance. Plantinga needs the possibility of this condition, not proof that it actually obtains.

[OBJECTION] Why could God not create free persons who always freely choose the good, as the blessed might in heaven?

[REPLY] A world-description in which creatures happen always to choose rightly may be logically describable, yet not strongly actualizable by God if the counterfactuals of their free choices are not under divine control. The heaven objection remains a plausibility pressure: if confirmed freedom without sin is coherent eschatologically, the theist must explain why earthly formation requires a different risk structure.

3.3 Natural evil extension and residual limits

[THESIS] The defence is strongest for moral evil. Plantinga suggested that natural evil could possibly involve non-human free agents; this is enough for bare logical compatibility if coherent, but it is not an evidentially attractive explanation for disease, tectonics or evolution.

[OBJECTION] The actual scale of natural and animal suffering far exceeds what creaturely moral freedom explains.

[REPLY] The theist may combine freedom with stable-law, soul-making or finite-creation accounts. Combining theories, however, increases explanatory commitments and must not become an unfalsifiable list.

[VERDICT] Plantinga is widely taken to have neutralized the strongest deductive version of the problem. He does not establish that God probably exists, that transworld depravity is actual, or that observed natural evil is justified.

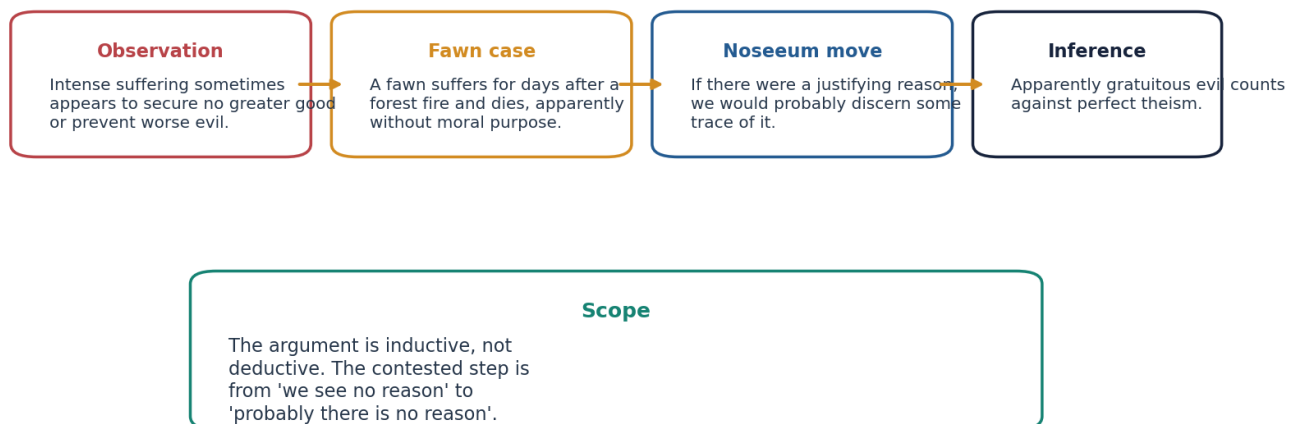
Conceptual drill

Classify each claim:

1. "There is no contradiction if freedom possibly requires risk." - **Defence / compatibility.**
2. "God actually permits suffering to mature persons." - **Theodicy / actual reason.**
3. "The quantity of suffering is unexpected on theism." - **Evidential challenge.**
4. "No harmony can justify a tortured child." - **Moral protest / anti-theodicy.**

Session 4 - Evidential Evil: Rowe, Probability and Skeptical Theism

Rowe's evidential argument and the fawn case



The scale, distribution and intensity of suffering strengthen the cumulative evidential case.

Rowe's evidential argument

4.1 Rowe and apparently gratuitous suffering

[THESIS] William Rowe's evidential argument grants that God and evil may be logically compatible. It argues that some intense suffering appears gratuitous: an omnipotent, omniscient being could prevent it without losing a greater good or permitting an equal or worse evil.

[ARGUMENT]

1. There exist instances of intense suffering that an omnipotent, omniscient being could have prevented without losing a greater good or permitting an equal or worse evil.
2. A perfectly good being would prevent any such suffering.
3. Therefore, probably, no omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good being exists.

Rowe's well-known example is a fawn badly burned in a forest fire, suffering for days before death, with no visible connection to moral agency or a beneficiary. The case is illustrative, not a claim that one event alone deductively disproves God.

4.2 The noseem inference

[THESIS] Evidential force depends on a noseem move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room. It is weak when the reason could exceed their access.

[OBJECTION] God's providential reasons, long causal chains and goods involving many lives may exceed human perspective.

[REPLY] Mere logical possibility of an unknown reason cannot erase all evidence. In ordinary reasoning, absence of expected evidence can be evidence of absence. The real question is whether humans should expect access to divine justifying reasons.

4.3 Draper and conceptual Bayesian framing

[QUALIFICATION] Paul Draper's evidential strategy, where used, compares hypotheses: the biological distribution of pain and pleasure may be less surprising on an indifferent naturalistic hypothesis than on perfect theism. The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.

[ARGUMENT] Conceptually:

Posterior plausibility of theism
depends on prior plausibility
multiplied by how expected the evidence is if theism is true.

If evolutionary suffering is much more expected on indifferent nature than on perfect providence, it counts against theism, unless independent evidence or a strong auxiliary theodicy offsets it.

[QUALIFICATION] Bayesian language disciplines comparison but cannot manufacture agreed priors or likelihoods. Avoid pseudo-precision in an UPSC answer.

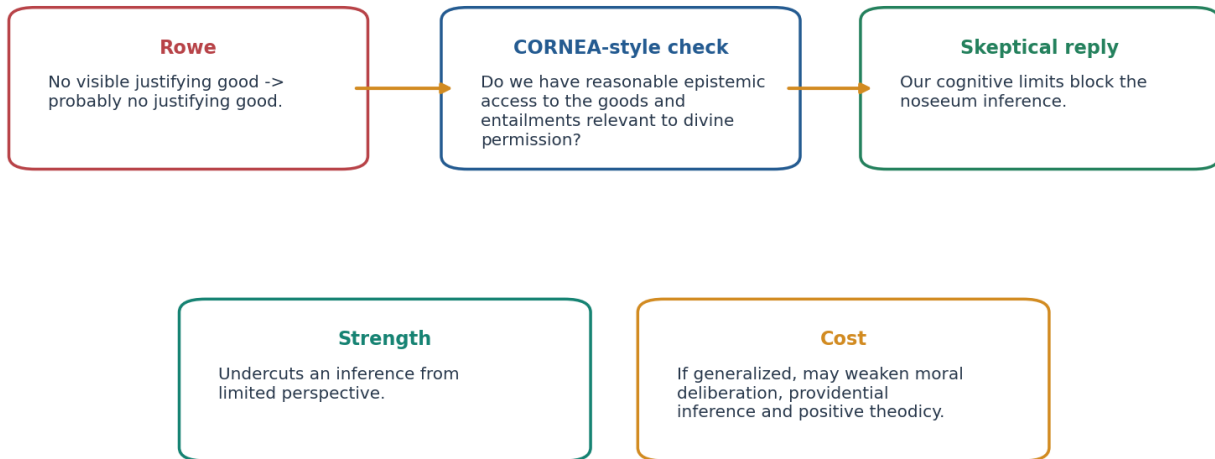
4.4 Scale, distribution, intensity and hiddenness

Evidential dimension	Question
Scale	Why is there so much suffering rather than the minimum needed for freedom or growth?
Distribution	Why does suffering fall so unevenly, including on infants and animals?
Intensity	Why do some harms destroy agency rather than challenge it?
Duration	Why do harms continue when their lesson or causal role seems exhausted?
Hiddenness cross-link	Why does a loving God remain obscure to sincere sufferers?

[QUALIFICATION] Divine hiddenness is a bounded cross-link, not a substitute topic. Here it matters because available comfort, guidance or unmistakable presence might reduce suffering without cancelling freedom.

4.5 Skeptical theism

Skeptical theism: response tree and cost



Use as a bounded epistemic defence, not a licence to call every horror secretly necessary.

Skeptical-theism response tree

[THESIS] Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it. Bergmann-style representativeness theses deny that our sample of goods, evils and entailment relations is representative of the full moral order.

[OBJECTION] Broad skepticism threatens ordinary moral reasoning: if unknown goods may justify any horror, how can one condemn or prevent evil?

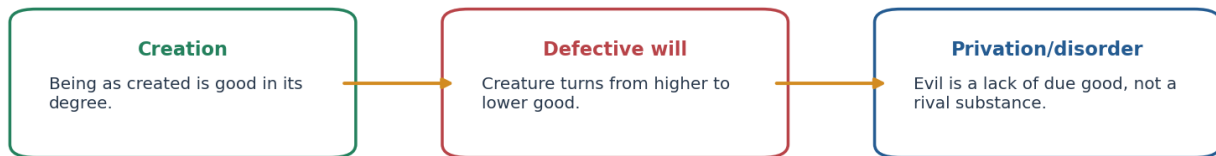
[REPLY] The view can be restricted to global inferences about what an omniscient governor may permit, while preserving local duties based on known reasons. We should prevent suffering because we lack authority to assume an unknown justifying plan.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism weakens Rowe's inference but carries costs. It sits uneasily beside confident positive theodicies, can weaken providential interpretation, and must be bounded to avoid moral paralysis.

Session 5 - Classical Theodicies and Defences

5.1 Augustine: privation, fall and free will

Augustinian privation, fall and punishment model



Privation says evil is parasitic, not imaginary; it still needs a causal and moral account of the lack.

Augustinian privation and fall

Augustinian privation theory

[THESIS] Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

[ARGUMENT] An eye is a good organ; blindness is the lack of a function due to it. Likewise, a will is good as a created capacity but becomes evil by disordered attachment to a lesser good over the highest good. Moral evil originates in defective creaturely willing. In Augustine's larger narrative, natural disorder and suffering are connected with fall and punishment.

[QUALIFICATION] **What it preserves or explains:** It avoids a Manichaean dualism of two rival substances and locates culpability in creaturely agency.

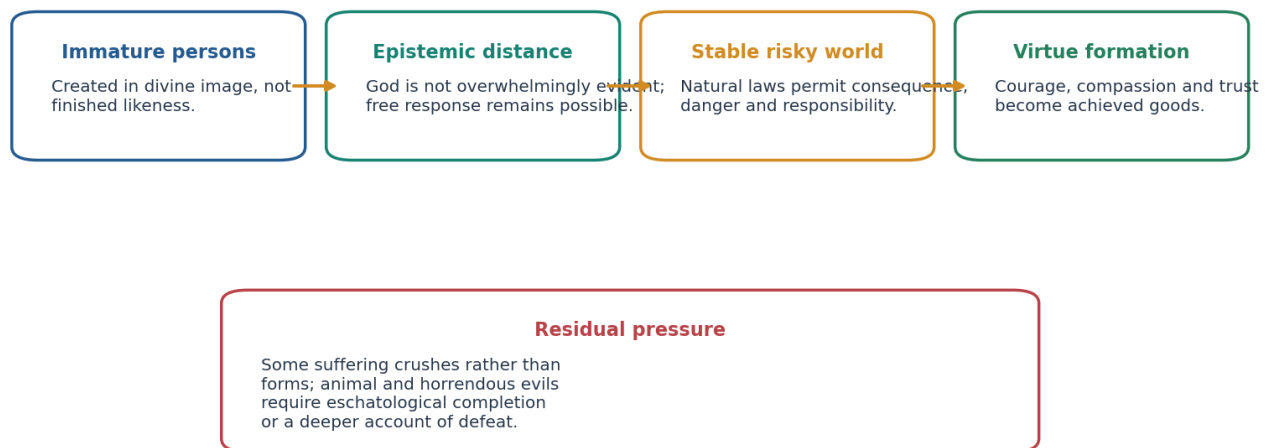
[OBJECTION] A lack can be painfully real, so privation alone does not explain why God permits it. Pre-human predation, disease and extinction strain a historical account that treats natural evil as punishment for a human fall. The origin of a defect in an originally flawless creation is also difficult.

[REPLY] Privation is a metaphysical analysis, not denial of suffering. Defenders may read fall non-literally as the structural misuse of finite freedom, but this revision weakens the exact punitive claim.

[VERDICT] The theory is strong against the claim that God created an evil substance and strong on moral disorder; it is incomplete as a morally persuasive explanation of innocent, animal and evolutionary suffering.

5.2 Irenaeus and Hick: developmental soul-making

Irenaean-Hick soul-making process



Irenaeus supplies the developmental theology; Keats supplies 'vale of soul-making'; Hick modernizes the theodicy.

Irenaean-Hick developmental model

Irenaean-Hick soul-making

[THESIS] Humans are created as immature persons capable of development toward divine likeness; a world of epistemic distance, stable law and real danger permits freely achieved virtue.

[ARGUMENT] Ready-made innocence is not mature goodness. Courage presupposes danger, compassion another's need, forgiveness wrongdoing, and responsible action predictable consequences. Hick contrasts a soul-making world with a hedonistic paradise that continuously adjusts to desire. Irenaeus supplies the image-to-likeness developmental theology; John Keats supplies the phrase 'vale of soul-making'; Hick develops the modern theodicy.

[QUALIFICATION] **What it preserves or explains:** It addresses moral and natural evil within one developmental framework and explains why God is not overwhelmingly evident.

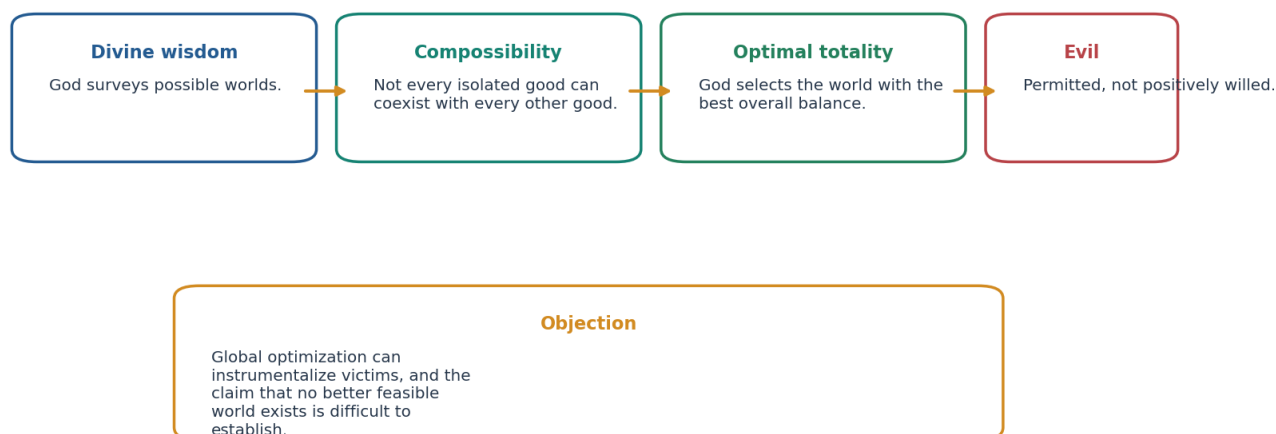
[OBJECTION] Much suffering destroys character, occurs before moral agency, or affects animals. The quantity needed for growth seems lower than the quantity observed. It also risks using victims as instruments for others' virtue.

[REPLY] Hick invokes eventual eschatological fulfilment so no life is finally wasted, and stresses that freedom and stable order require genuine risk.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains a class of hardships better than horrendous or apparently pointless evils. Eschatology may compensate or defeat evil, but compensation alone does not prove permission was justified.

5.3 Leibniz: best possible world

Leibniz: best possible world defence



Best-world reasoning concerns the total order; it does not make each event locally best.

Leibniz best-world defence

Leibnizian best-world reasoning

[THESIS] A perfectly wise and good God creates the best among possible worlds, where 'best' concerns the complete compossible order rather than the local pleasantness of each event.

[ARGUMENT] Possible goods can conflict: stable laws, freedom, regular causation and rich varieties of being may jointly entail permitted defects. God antecedently wills good and permits evil as part of an optimal totality rather than positively willing evil as evil.

[QUALIFICATION] **What it preserves or explains:** It highlights systemic trade-offs and rejects the naive inference that omnipotence can combine every isolated advantage.

[OBJECTION] The claim that this is the best feasible world is hard to verify, and global optimization can turn sufferers into expendable parts. Voltairean ridicule targets facile optimism rather than the bare logic of compossibility.

[REPLY] The defender can distinguish 'best total world' from 'best event' and insist that victims are included within final divine goodness, not sacrificed outside it.

[VERDICT] Compossibility is a valuable modal insight, but the best-world claim requires an ethically credible goodness-to-persons account.

5.4 Greater-good, law-governed order and Swinburne-style responsibility

[THESIS] A regular world is necessary for knowledge, prediction, action and moral responsibility. Fire must burn, gravity must operate and biological processes must be sufficiently stable; otherwise consequences would be arbitrary and agency trivial.

[ARGUMENT] Stable laws create both enabling goods and exposure to harm. If God constantly cancelled dangerous effects, agents could not learn causal structure, bear responsibility or help one another under genuine stakes. Some writers, including Swinburne in standard discussions, emphasize the value of serious responsibility and the opportunity to respond to others.

[OBJECTION] Regularity explains why some harms occur, not why preventable excess, extreme intensity or selective miracles are absent. A less dangerous law-system may still support agency.

[REPLY] Counterfactual comparison among entire law-systems is difficult, and complex life may require vulnerability. Yet the burden remains to explain why the actual distribution is not gratuitously severe.

[VERDICT] Natural-law reasoning is a plausible necessary-condition account, not a complete sufficient justification.

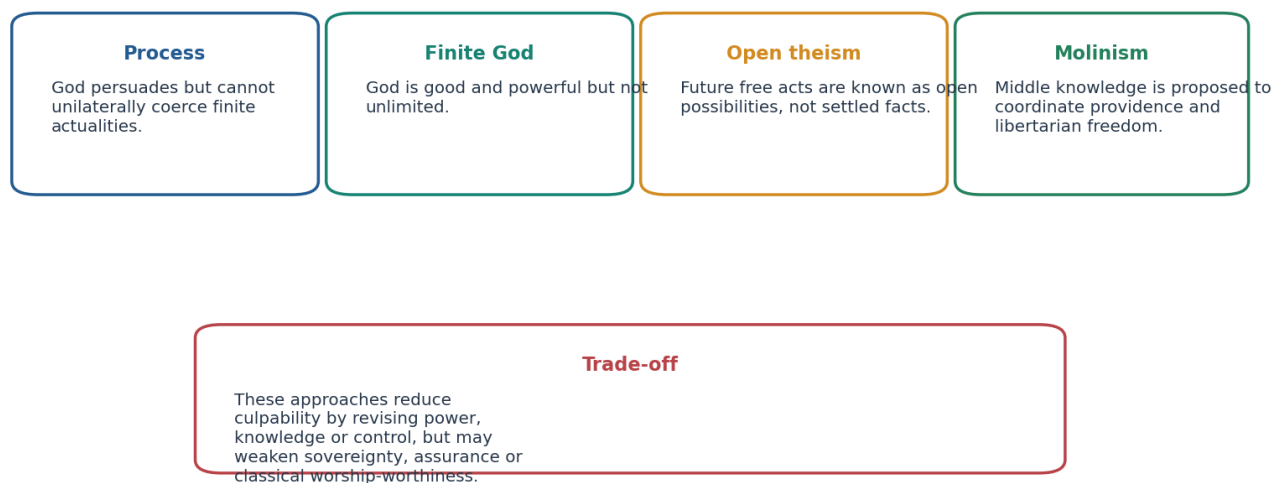
5.5 Punishment, discipline and providence - use with caution

[QUALIFICATION] Retributive punishment may explain a wrongdoer's suffering only where guilt, proportionality and legitimate authority are established. It cannot be casually applied to infants, disasters, animals or inherited conditions. Disciplinary suffering may sometimes reform, but uninvited observers lack warrant to label another's trauma a divine lesson.

[VERDICT] In an exam, present punishment and discipline as limited traditional motifs, then impose proportionality, innocence and victim-blaming constraints.

Session 6 - Non-Classical Theisms and Revised Divine Attributes

Revising classical theism relocates the problem



Rejecting classical attributes can dissolve the contradiction while creating a new religious cost.

Process, finite, open and Molinist revisions

6.1 Process theodicy: Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb

[THESIS] Process thought does not preserve classical unilateral omnipotence. Reality consists in becoming actualities with their own measure of self-determination; God supplies persuasive possibilities but cannot simply coerce every event.

[ARGUMENT]

1. Actual entities are partly self-creative; power is intrinsically distributed.
2. God has a primordial aspect ordering possibilities and offering an initial aim, and a consequent aspect receiving the world's achieved values.
3. Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.
4. Evil arises when finite actualities fail to realize better possibilities or when incompatible processes collide.
5. God is not the author of evil and receives the world's suffering in divine experience.

[QUALIFICATION] Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology. Do not collapse their distinct roles.

[OBJECTION] A God unable to prevent horror may not be worthy of worship and may not guarantee final victory.

[REPLY] Process thinkers answer that coercive omnipotence is incoherent in a world of genuinely actual others; supreme persuasive power and perfect solidarity are more religiously adequate than total control.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy purchases divine innocence and solidarity at the price of classical sovereignty. That trade-off is its strength and its cost.

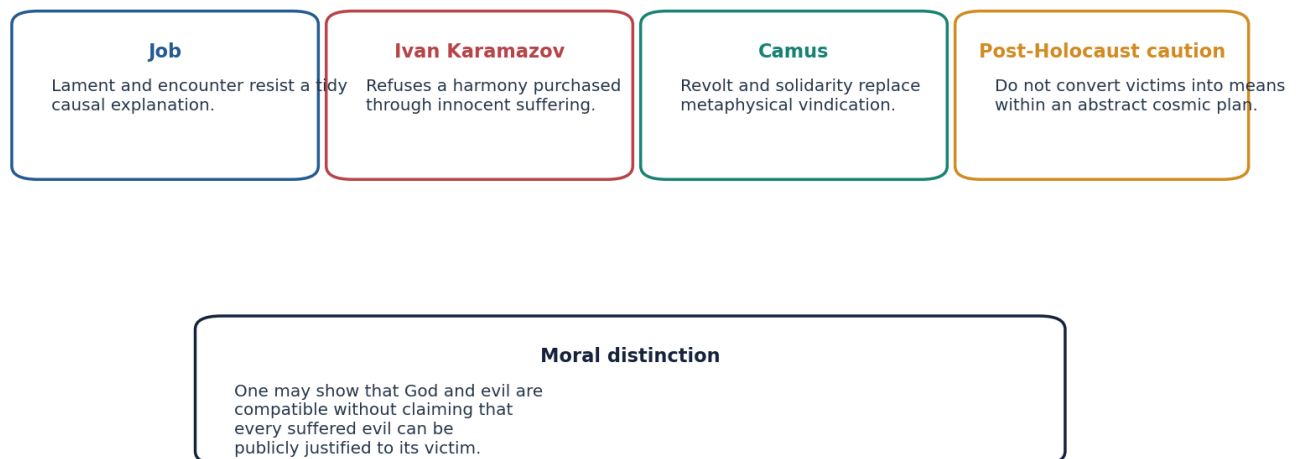
6.2 Finite God, open theism and Molinism

- **Finite-God views** preserve goodness while limiting power. They relocate evil from culpable permission to cosmic struggle, but weaken assurance.
- **Open theism** holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts. It reduces the control entailed by exhaustive definite foreknowledge, but critics call this a loss of perfection.
- **Molinism**, where invoked, appeals to divine middle knowledge of what free creatures would do in possible circumstances. It seeks meticulous providence without causal determination. Its controversial counterfactuals and the persistence of feasible-world limits must be acknowledged.
- **Kenotic or cruciform approaches** stress divine self-emptying, participation and co-suffering. They may transform the existential relation to suffering without by themselves explaining why permission was necessary.

[VERDICT] Revising an attribute can dissolve the original inconsistent set, but it does not make suffering disappear. The problem is relocated to adequacy of worship, providence, hope and the metaphysics of divine-world interaction.

Session 7 - Existential Evil, Protest and Horrendous Evils

Existential protest and anti-theodicy



Anti-theodicy tests the ethics of explanation, not only the validity of an argument.

Existential protest and anti-theodicy

7.1 Job, Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky and Camus

[THESIS] Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

- **Job** dramatizes lament, accusation, friendship's failed explanations and a transformed encounter. It should not be reduced to a neat punishment theory.
- **Kierkegaard**, where relevant, illuminates the risk and inwardness of faith under objective uncertainty; he does not supply a standard causal theodicy.
- **Dostoevsky's Ivan Karamazov** refuses a final harmony purchased through innocent suffering. The force is moral protest: even if an explanation exists, may one accept its price?
- **Camus** rejects metaphysical vindication and stresses revolt, solidarity and refusal to add human cruelty to an indifferent or absurd condition.

[VERDICT] These voices expose a gap between solving consistency and responding to victims. They are not substitutes for formal argument; they test its existential and ethical adequacy.

7.2 Holocaust and post-Holocaust caution

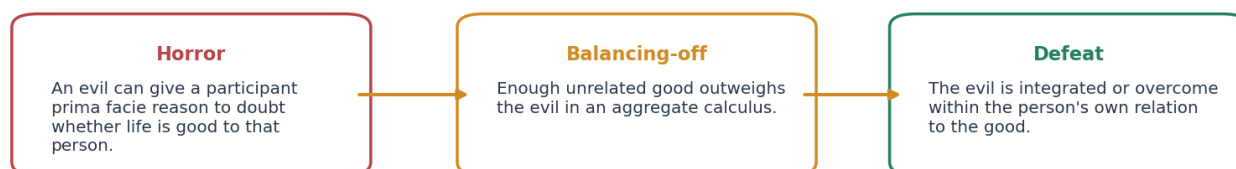
[QUALIFICATION] Post-Holocaust reflection warns against speaking as if atrocity were a necessary ingredient in a divine plan. Source-owned thinkers may differ: some revise divine power, some prioritize testimony and responsibility, and some reject comprehensive theodicy. An UPSC answer should avoid attributing one uniform doctrine to "post-Holocaust theology."

[THESIS] The moral danger is instrumentalization: treating victims' suffering as a means to another person's virtue, historical progress or cosmic beauty.

[REPLY] A restrained defence may claim only that God and evil are not contradictory, while refusing to specify the purpose of each atrocity. Religious practice may take the form of lament, remembrance, resistance and solidarity rather than explanation.

7.3 Marilyn McCord Adams and horrendous evils

Horrendous evils: balancing-off versus defeat



Eschatological compensation is not automatically justification; defeat is stronger than replacement.

Horrendous evils and defeat

[THESIS] Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them. The problem is not merely aggregate quantity but goodness-to-the-person.

[ARGUMENT] **Balancing-off** adds enough independent good to outweigh an evil. **Defeat** integrates or overcomes the evil within the sufferer's own life and relation to the good, so it no longer has the last word about the value of that life. Adams's framework pressures theodicy to address personal redemption rather than cosmic bookkeeping.

[OBJECTION] Eschatological intimacy or redemption can sound like compensation after an unjust permission.

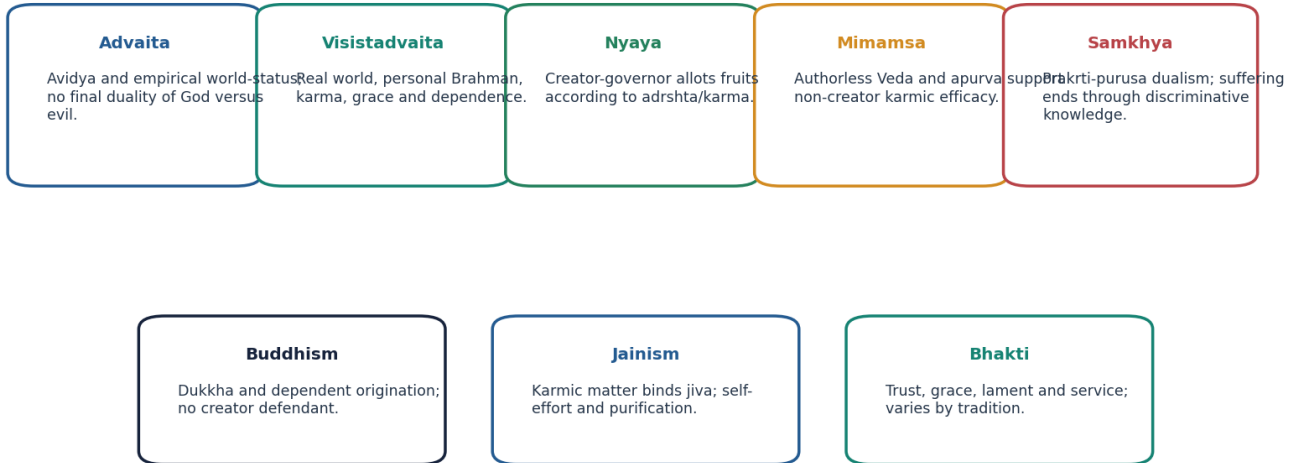
[REPLY] Defenders distinguish defeat from replacement: the evil must be personally integrated, not forgotten beneath unrelated rewards.

[VERDICT] The framework deepens soul-making, but it also shows why no general-purpose developmental story is sufficient for horrors.

Session 8 - Indian and Non-Western Frameworks

8.1 Method: no single "Indian solution"

Indian schools: do not homogenize the response



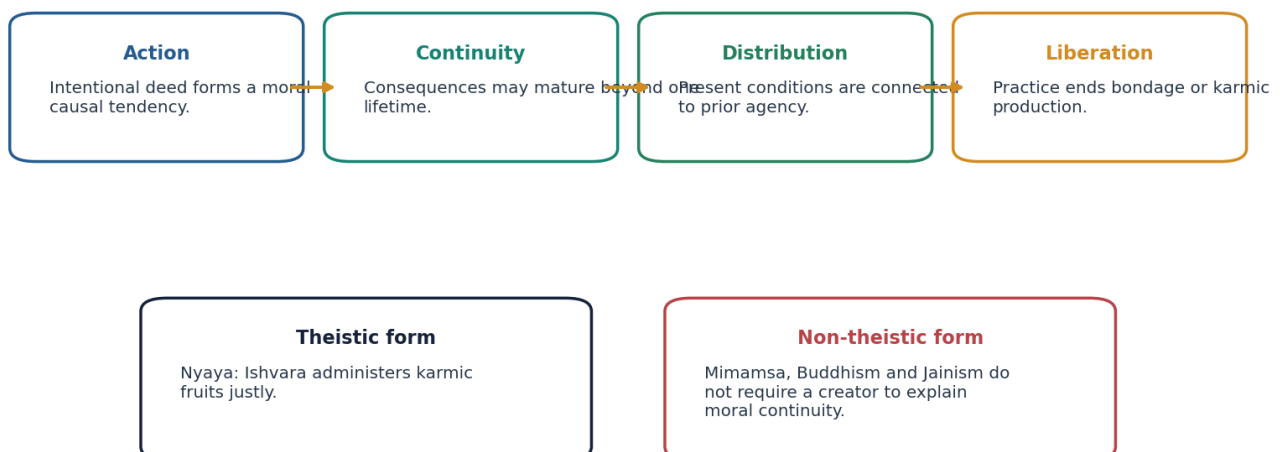
Creator-theist and non-creator frameworks answer different versions of the problem.

Indian school comparison

[THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation. Creator-theist systems face a permission and administration problem; non-creator systems reframe evil as bondage, ignorance, craving or karmic causation.

8.2 Karma and rebirth

Karma and rebirth: explanatory model and critique



Critiques: regress, memory and identity, victim blaming, and social legitimation; compassion remains obligatory.

Karma-rebirth model and critique

[THESIS] Karma connects intentional action with morally structured consequence, often across rebirth. It can explain distribution without making present innocence the whole history of agency.

[ARGUMENT] Action produces a causal potency or karmic consequence; continuity across lives widens the field in which consequences mature; present suffering may therefore be connected to prior agency; liberation ends bondage

or the production of future consequences.

[QUALIFICATION] This abstract scheme differs by school:

- **Nyaya:** Ishvara can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator. The critic can still ask why an omnipotent administrator chose this painful mechanism.
- **Mimamsa:** ritual action and *apurva* support karmic efficacy without a creator-God; the classical theistic defendant is absent.
- **Advaita:** suffering belongs to the empirical order structured by ignorance, karma and identification. Ultimate non-duality changes the metaphysical status of the problem, but calling suffering empirically real prevents a crude "mere illusion" dismissal.
- **Visistadvaita:** selves and world are real and dependent on a personal Brahman; karma, grace and divine governance must be held together. Do not assimilate it to Advaita.
- **Dvaita:** real difference, personal God and moral agency preserve a robust theistic framework; attribution should remain general unless a source securely establishes a specific theodicy.
- **Samkhya:** without a creator, suffering arises through the conjunction and misidentification of purusha with prakriti; discriminative knowledge yields isolation. This diagnoses bondage rather than justifying divine permission.

8.3 Critiques of karma

[OBJECTION]

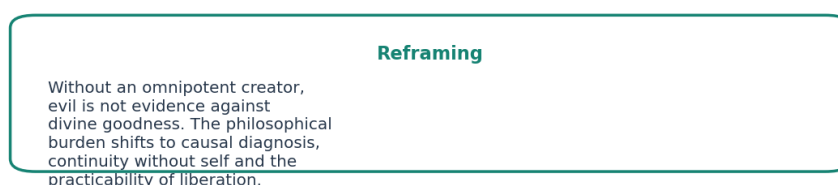
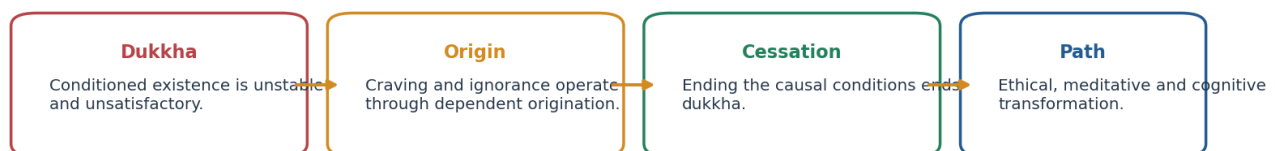
1. **Victim blaming:** present suffering may be treated as deserved.
2. **Regress:** if every suffering is explained by prior deed, what explains the beginning of the cycle?
3. **Memory and identity:** why is punishment just if the sufferer cannot remember the deed or if personal identity is disputed?
4. **Social legitimization:** karmic rhetoric can naturalize hierarchy and reduce reform.
5. **Proportionality and mechanism:** the link between a specific deed and suffering may be opaque.

[REPLY] Traditions can call samsara beginningless rather than posit a first deed; moral continuity need not require episodic memory; and present compassion remains obligatory because another's karma never licenses one's cruelty or indifference.

[VERDICT] Karma is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim. Explanation must be separated from blame.

8.4 Buddhism: dukkha and dependent origination

Buddhist reframing: from creator-defence to diagnosis of dukkha



Buddhism does not 'solve' the classical theistic problem; it changes the explanatory question.

[THESIS] Buddhism does not defend an omnipotent creator. It begins from *dukkha*, traces its conditioned arising through craving and ignorance, affirms cessation and prescribes a path.

[ARGUMENT] The philosophical focus shifts from "Why would God permit this?" to "What conditions generate suffering and how can they cease?" Dependent origination avoids both an uncaused creator and a permanent self-substance, though it must explain karmic responsibility through causal continuity.

[OBJECTION] A diagnostic path may not answer why the world contains horrific suffering or why causal continuity is morally just without a stable self.

[REPLY] Buddhism need not justify a created totality; it offers a practical causal explanation and liberation project. Responsibility can attach to causal continuity without numerical identity, though this remains contested.

[VERDICT] Buddhism dissolves the classical problem by removing its divine defendant but retains the existential and ethical urgency of suffering.

8.5 Jainism

[THESIS] Jainism treats karma as subtle material bondage adhering to jiva through passion and action. Influx, bondage, stoppage and shedding explain suffering and liberation through self-effort, discipline and non-violence without a creator.

[OBJECTION] Materialized karma and beginningless bondage raise explanatory questions; strict ascetic responsibility can become harsh if applied without compassion.

[REPLY] The framework links metaphysics to ethical purification and radical *ahimsa*, making prevention of harm central rather than passive acceptance.

[VERDICT] Jainism replaces theodicy with a bondage-liberation mechanics; it avoids creator culpability while retaining burdens concerning karmic proportionality and identity.

8.6 Bhakti and providence

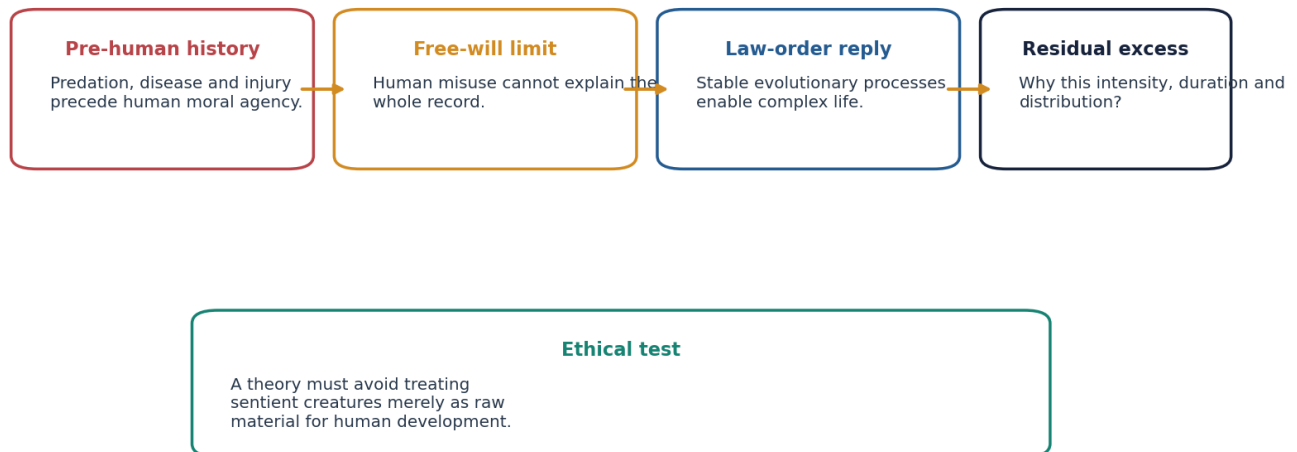
[QUALIFICATION] Bhakti traditions vary. Relevant responses include trust, surrender, lament, grace, divine companionship and service. They should not be presented as a single proof that every suffering is providentially designed.

[VERDICT] Bhakti contributes an existential relation and practice; philosophical adequacy still requires an account of power, permission, karma and innocent suffering.

Session 9 - Hard Cases and Meta-Level Critiques

9.1 Animal suffering and evolutionary evil

Animal suffering and evolutionary evil



Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge, not a footnote to moral evil.

Animal suffering and evolutionary evil

[THESIS] Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

[OBJECTION] Free-will and punishment theories are anthropocentric. Stable-law and evolutionary accounts explain mechanisms and goods such as complex life, but not obviously the intensity and duration of sentient pain.

[REPLY] Theists may appeal to the value of an autonomous, fecund creation, regular processes and possible non-human redemption. Each proposal carries speculative commitments and must not treat animals merely as instruments for human virtues.

[VERDICT] Animal evil sharply limits any total theodicy based only on human freedom or character.

9.2 Free will and heaven

[OBJECTION] If persons in heaven are free yet do not sin, why could God not create that condition immediately?

[REPLY] The soul-making answer distinguishes created innocence from formed character: confirmed goodness may be the outcome of a history of free development. The critic asks whether horrendous risks are necessary for that history and whether all persons receive a fair developmental environment.

[VERDICT] Heaven pressures but does not automatically refute freedom-based accounts; it forces a temporal and developmental explanation.

9.3 Natural laws and preventable excess

[THESIS] A law-governed order explains regular vulnerability. It does not entail that every actual harm or every degree of harm is required.

[OBJECTION] Selective prevention could preserve laws while avoiding isolated horrors.

[REPLY] Frequent hidden intervention might destabilize agency, but rare intervention need not. The persistence of apparently preventable excess remains an evidential residue.

9.4 Afterlife compensation versus justification

[THESIS] Compensation gives a later good; justification shows permission was morally acceptable; defeat integrates the evil within the sufferer's good. These are not equivalent.

[OBJECTION] Infinite future bliss may outweigh finite pain but cannot retroactively make using a person permissible.

[REPLY] A goodness-to-persons theory requires more than arithmetic: consent, relationship, redemption and defeat matter.

9.5 Epistemic humility versus skepticism

[THESIS] Humility recognizes limited perspective. Skepticism becomes costly when it blocks all moral assessment, providential inference or positive religious knowledge.

[VERDICT] The strongest bounded position is asymmetric: do not infer confidently that every evil is gratuitous, but do not infer confidently that every evil serves a hidden good. Act against suffering using known reasons.

9.6 Theodicy as explanation or moral legitimation

[OBJECTION] Theodicy can legitimate the status quo by redescribing oppression as discipline, karma or providence.

[REPLY] A morally responsible theodicy must be action-guiding: because agents do not know hidden purposes, they must prevent harms, resist injustice and refuse victim blame. Any view that weakens compassion fails its own claim to goodness.

9.7 Does rejecting classical theism dissolve the problem?

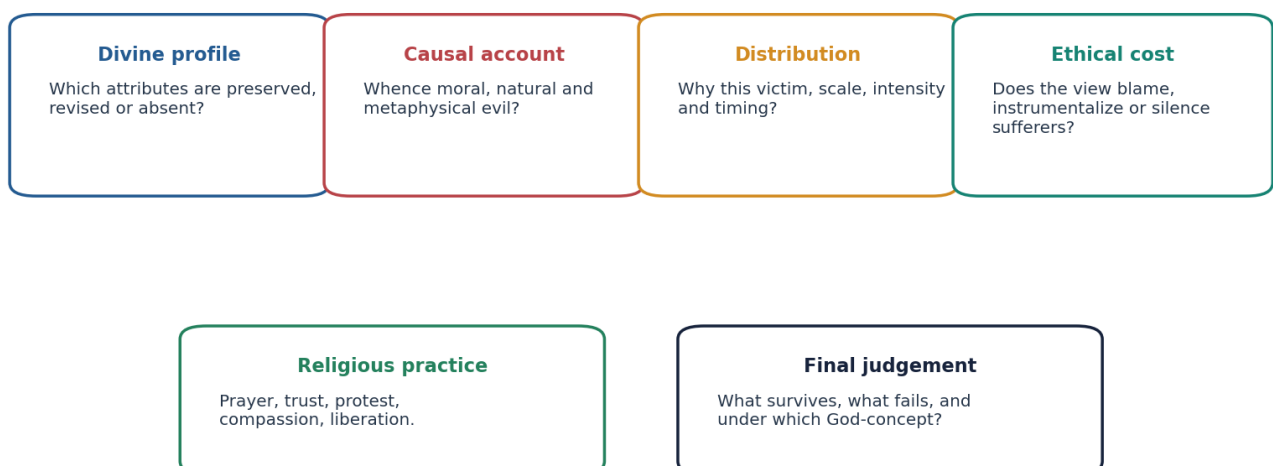
[THESIS] Removing omnipotence, creatorhood or personal goodness dissolves the original inconsistent triad.

[QUALIFICATION] It relocates rather than abolishes questions: Is a finite God worship-worthy? Can process God save? Does non-theistic karma fairly distribute consequence? Does Advaitic world-status respect empirical suffering? Can Buddhism ground continuity and compassion without self?

[VERDICT] The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.

Session 10 - Comparative Synthesis and Practical Implications

Comparative essay matrix: what every theory must answer



Comparison must be multi-axis; a single 'best theodicy' ranking is philosophically crude.

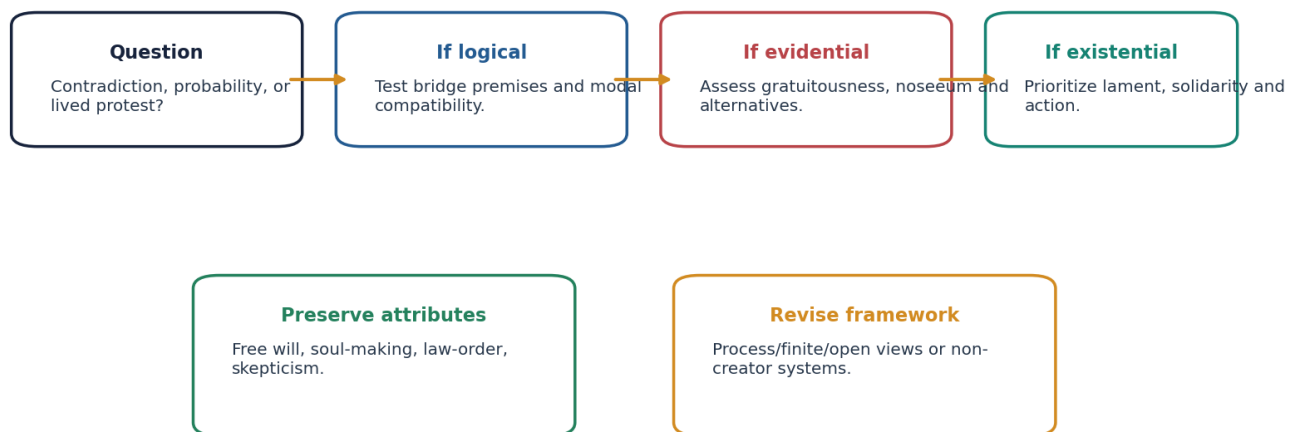
Comparative essay matrix

10.1 Multi-axis comparison

View	Divine attributes	Cause/account	Natural/animal evil	Distribution	Ethical cost
Plantinga	Preserves classical profile	Misuse of significant freedom	Needs supplement	Weak	Can look modally remote
Augustine	Preserves profile	Privation, fall, punishment	Historically strained	Punitive	Innocent suffering and inherited guilt
Hick	Preserves goodness and broad power	Development under epistemic distance	Law-order and growth	Uneven opportunity	Instrumentalization; excess
Leibniz	Preserves perfection	Best compossible totality	Part of system	Global, not personal	Sacrificial optimization
Process	Revises omnipotence	Distributed power and finite becoming	Built into process risk	No unilateral controller	Weakened assurance
Skeptical theism	Preserves attributes without reason claim	Epistemic undercutting	Unexplained	Unexplained	Moral skepticism risk
Karma-theistic	Just administrator	Prior agency and divine allocation	Across life-series	Strong explanatory ambition	Victim blame; opacity
Karma-non-theistic	No creator defendant	Moral causation	Across life-series	Strong ambition	Regress/identity
Buddhism	No creator	Craving, ignorance, dependent arising	Conditioned dukkha	Not distributive theodicy	May seem diagnosis without cosmic why
Jainism	No creator	Karmic matter and passion	Bondage across jivas	Karmic continuity	Ascetic severity

10.2 Objection-response decision tree

Objection-response decision tree



A high-scoring answer first identifies the exact problem and only then chooses a response.

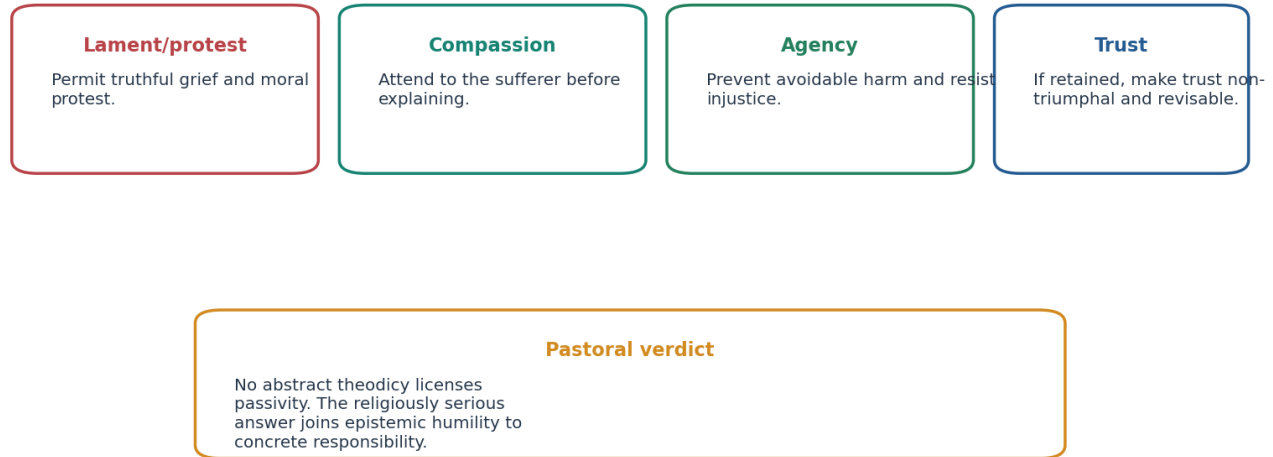
Objection-response decision tree

1. Identify whether the examiner asks contradiction, probability, responsibility, conceptual dependence or religious function.
2. State the divine profile under examination.
3. Reconstruct one argument formally.
4. Deploy only responses that meet that argument's burden.

5. Add one Indian comparison that changes the frame rather than decorating the answer.
6. State the moral and religious cost of the response.

10.3 Practical religious implications

From puzzle to practice: a responsible religious response



Prayer and protest can coexist; explanation must never replace care.

Pastoral and practical response

[THESIS] The practical test of a religious response is whether it deepens truthfulness, compassion and responsibility rather than silencing lament.

- **Prayer:** may include petition, lament, protest and solidarity; unanswered prayer intensifies rather than cancels the philosophical issue.
- **Trust:** can be retained as fallible commitment without claiming knowledge of each divine reason.
- **Protest:** need not be unbelief; Job-like protest can occur within a relationship.
- **Compassion:** precedes explanation in pastoral settings.
- **Moral action:** no theodicy licenses passivity. Agents must prevent avoidable suffering because they are not entitled to assume it is necessary.
- **Religious commitment:** may survive through a cumulative judgement involving experience, practice and other arguments, but evil remains a defeater that must be answered rather than ignored.

[VERDICT] The mature position combines conceptual rigor, epistemic humility and victim-centered action.

Advanced Seminar Modules - From Competent to Examiner-Grade

11. Modal logic without notation overload

[THESIS] The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true together in at least one possible world. The critic alleges that no possible world contains both the classical God and evil; the defender needs only one coherent possibility in which God has a morally sufficient reason to permit evil.

[ARGUMENT] Three modal ideas must be kept separate. First, **logical possibility** means that a description contains no contradiction. Second, **world feasibility** asks whether God can actualize that description given truths about undetermined creaturely choices. Third, **actuality** asks which world and history obtain. Plantinga argues at the first two levels. He does not infer that the freedom story is the actual divine policy merely because it is possible.

[OBJECTION] The distinction between possible and feasible worlds appears to limit divine power by facts God does not control. If counterfactuals of freedom are independently true, what grounds them, and why cannot an omnipotent creator choose better agents or circumstances?

[REPLY] Libertarian freedom precisely denies that God determines the content of the free choice. The defender can say that creating agents includes accepting truths about how those agents would freely respond. The grounding question remains a serious objection to Molinist and feasible-world accounts, but it is not a proof of contradiction.

[QUALIFICATION] In an UPSC answer, modal vocabulary should clarify rather than display technique. Write: "A logically describable sinless free world may not be strongly actualizable by God if the truth of free creaturely choices is not under divine causal control." Do not use symbols unless they reduce ambiguity.

[VERDICT] Modal analysis is most successful as a negative result: the simple inconsistent-set argument needs more than the bare triad. It leaves open whether the actual world is a reasonable choice for a perfectly good creator.

12. The moral premises behind the logical problem

[THESIS] The dispute is not only about divine power. It is also about the content of goodness. The premise "a good being eliminates evil" is too strong unless it includes "when elimination does not sacrifice an equal or greater good, violate another's agency, or permit an equal or worse evil."

[ARGUMENT] Ordinary morality permits painful surgery, dangerous education and enforcement of just law when proportionate and necessary. The theist generalizes: divine permission may be morally justified where a good is logically connected with risk. The critic answers that ordinary permission is constrained by consent, necessity, proportionality, fair distribution and accountability. A parent may allow a difficult examination but not torture a child for character. Therefore "greater good" is not a blank cheque.

[OBJECTION] Applying human moral constraints to God may be anthropomorphic because creatorhood changes the relation between giver of life and creature.

[REPLY] If divine goodness has no recognizable continuity with moral goodness, the theist loses the very premise used to praise and worship God. Analogical predication may allow difference of mode, not reversal of evaluative content.

[QUALIFICATION] This creates a dilemma for extreme skeptical theism. Too much confidence in human moral standards makes evil evidentially forceful; too little makes "God is good" thin and removes the basis for positive theodicy.

[VERDICT] The logical problem is best understood as a stress-test of perfect goodness under the conditions of creator responsibility, not as a mechanical contradiction among three dictionary definitions.

13. Freedom: value, range and responsibility

[THESIS] Free-will approaches require more than the assertion that freedom is valuable. They must specify the kind of freedom, the range of consequences necessary for responsibility, and the distribution of opportunities for meaningful choice.

[ARGUMENT] Libertarian freedom holds that at least some choices are not determined by prior conditions. Compatibilist freedom identifies acting from one's own reasons without external constraint even if those reasons are causally determined. Plantinga's defence needs a libertarian relation to God: if God determines the choice, creaturely authorship cannot wholly transfer moral responsibility. Yet significant freedom need not entail unlimited power to harm. Human societies rightly restrict weapons and opportunities for catastrophic wrongdoing while preserving agency. The critic therefore asks why God permits consequences far beyond what meaningful choice needs.

[OBJECTION] Continuous divine restriction would make the world a moral nursery, obscure causal responsibility and prevent serious cooperation against evil.

[REPLY] The objection supports some regular consequences, not every scale of consequence. The theist must explain a threshold: which harms are integral to responsible agency and which are apparently excessive?

[QUALIFICATION] Social and structural evil complicates individualistic freedom. Poverty, oppression and institutions are produced through many choices and inherited systems. No single agent may intend the total harm, yet

responsibility is distributed. A theodicy centered only on isolated decisions misses this cumulative structure.

[VERDICT] Freedom plausibly explains the possibility of moral fault. It less clearly explains the available magnitude of harm, unequal moral opportunity, structural evil and divine non-restraint.

14. Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess

[THESIS] A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied life, scientific understanding and purposive action. Some contemporary formulations describe creation as having relative autonomy rather than being a theatre of continuous intervention.

[ARGUMENT] Regular tectonics, weather, mutation, immunity and ecological competition have life-enabling and harm-producing aspects. A world in which harmful effects vanished whenever they threatened a person would cease to be cognitively reliable. Agents could not infer causes, coordinate plans or develop technologies. This supports a general permission of natural risk.

[OBJECTION] The critic distinguishes law from initial conditions, regularity from intensity, and ordinary vulnerability from apparently pointless agony. An omniscient designer could allegedly choose different constants, safer organisms, earlier warnings or selective interventions without abolishing order.

[REPLY] Whole-system comparison is difficult: changes that remove one harm may remove goods or produce unknown harms. Complex adaptive systems may require trade-offs that local observers cannot calculate.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] Difficulty of comparison is epistemic modesty, not positive evidence that the actual balance is optimal. It blocks confident atheistic inference only to the extent that access is genuinely poor; it also blocks confident theodicy.

[VERDICT] Creation-autonomy and law-order accounts explain why a serious world cannot be a hedonistic paradise. The question of preventable excess remains the central evidential residue.

15. Evolutionary evil and deep time

[THESIS] Evolutionary history intensifies the problem because pain, predation, parasitism and mass extinction occur over immense pre-human periods. The data weaken any account that treats natural evil chiefly as punishment for human sin.

[ARGUMENT] Evolution through variation, selection and ecological interaction generates adaptive complexity but also waste, failed organisms and sentient suffering. A theist may value a creation capable of bringing forth novelty through lawful processes rather than receiving every form by direct fiat. Such fecundity can be a good. Nevertheless, the process contains beings who cannot understand danger, consent to risk or acquire human-style virtue.

[OBJECTION] Calling evolutionary suffering the price of autonomy treats animals as disposable means. If God values each sentient creature, a species-level good is insufficient.

[REPLY] A defender may extend eschatological or redemptive goodness to non-human creatures, or argue that creaturely value is not exhausted by painless duration. These proposals are philosophically possible but source-dependent and speculative.

[QUALIFICATION] Karmic rebirth across animal forms supplies a different continuity story, but it can moralize animal pain without accessible evidence of desert. Jain concern for graded living beings and radical non-violence provides an ethical response even where metaphysical explanation is disputed.

[VERDICT] Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy. A theory that mentions animals only as instruments for human growth is incomplete.

16. Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence

[THESIS] The evidential case is strongest when cumulative rather than dependent on one dramatic example. It combines apparently gratuitous instances with patterns of biological pain, unequal distribution, divine hiddenness and the failure of proposed reasons to cover all classes.

[ARGUMENT] Rowe asks whether at least one instance of intense suffering lacks a justifying connection. Draper asks a comparative question: is the pattern of pleasure and pain more expected if nature is indifferent than if guided by perfect benevolence? The two approaches can reinforce each other. Rowe supplies local cases; Draper supplies pattern comparison. Neither requires the claim that evil is logically incompatible with God.

[OBJECTION] Theism is not a single bare hypothesis. It may include freedom, stable law, soul-making, eschatology and independent evidence from religious experience or cosmological arguments. Evaluating one datum in isolation distorts a cumulative worldview.

[REPLY] Auxiliary theodicies must have independent motivation and predictive discipline. A view that adds a new hidden purpose for every counterexample becomes resistant to evidence. Other evidence for God can offset evil, but Topic 02 arguments must be weighed rather than presumed.

[QUALIFICATION] Do not assign invented numerical priors. State only the comparative structure: evidence confirms a hypothesis to the extent that it is more expected on that hypothesis than on its rivals.

[VERDICT] Evidential evil functions as an undercutting and rebutting consideration within a total case. It rarely yields a stand-alone mathematical conclusion, but it can be philosophically weighty.

17. Skeptical theism: three boundaries

[THESIS] Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

1. **Epistemic boundary:** Human ignorance concerns the full network of divine reasons; it does not imply ignorance of every local good, evil or causal relation.

2. **Moral boundary:** Agents must act on accessible moral reasons. Unknown divine permission never authorizes human infliction or neglect.

3. **Religious boundary:** If the view blocks all inference from worldly goods to providence, it cannot selectively block only negative evidence while retaining every positive sign.

[ARGUMENT] Wykstra's accessibility principle is plausible when the scale difference between human and divine cognition is relevant. Bergmann's representativeness concern likewise warns that sampled goods may not exhaust possible goods. But a complete suspension of inductive judgement would damage ordinary reasoning.

[OBJECTION] The asymmetry between divine and human perspectives may itself justify selective skepticism: evil-permission could involve remote entailments, while some positive religious experiences are direct.

[REPLY] That distinction must be argued case by case. It cannot be assumed merely to protect a favoured conclusion. Moreover, the more opaque divine purposes become, the harder it is to infer that God is trustworthy in the recognizable moral sense.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism is best used as a defeater-defeater against overconfident noseenum reasoning, followed immediately by an affirmation of local moral responsibility.

18. Soul-making under the proportionality test

[THESIS] Soul-making succeeds for obstacles proportionate to agency and fails when it treats all suffering as development irrespective of outcome.

[ARGUMENT] A developmental environment needs danger, resistance, uncertainty and other persons' needs. These conditions enable courage, patience, compassion and practical wisdom. Yet formation requires an agent capable of learning, a challenge within some range of response, and an opportunity for recovery. Horrendous evils can fragment memory, trust and agency. Infant death and much animal pain offer no obvious subject of moral formation.

[OBJECTION] Goods may accrue to communities or other persons, and eschatological life may complete development interrupted here.

[REPLY] Community goods do not automatically justify using one person as material for another. Eschatology can widen the developmental horizon only if the individual sufferer is restored and the evil defeated within that person's good.

[QUALIFICATION] The distinction between first-order evil and second-order good should never be written as "evil is necessary for good." Some second-order virtues need vulnerability, but the same virtue may be elicited by many degrees of hardship. Necessity and proportionality require separate argument.

[VERDICT] Hick supplies a powerful account of why a world with no adversity might be morally shallow. Adams supplies the needed correction: goodness must finally be goodness to persons.

19. Augustine after evolutionary criticism

[THESIS] Augustine's metaphysical privation claim can survive even if the historical-punitive account of natural evil is rejected.

[ARGUMENT] Corruption remains dependent on an underlying good: disease is malfunction of living systems, cruelty is disorder of agency, injustice is corruption of social relation. This ontological point does not require that earthquakes began after a first human sin. The historical fall narrative, by contrast, makes empirical and moral claims about original perfection, inherited disorder and punishment.

[OBJECTION] Separating privation from fall may save a fragment while abandoning the theodicy. Even if evil is ontologically parasitic, God creates the subjects and conditions in which privation occurs.

[REPLY] The defender can combine privation with finite creation and free development: a created world is good yet not divine or incapable of defect. This avoids dualism without claiming that every natural evil punishes sin.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] If defect is an inevitable condition of finite being, either God cannot create without evil or chooses a vulnerable order. The classical question returns at the level of creation.

[VERDICT] Use Augustine in layers. Privation is the strongest philosophical layer; defective freedom is strong for moral evil; universal punishment and a historical cosmic fall carry the heaviest burden.

20. Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation

[THESIS] Process non-coercion and classical kenotic self-limitation must be distinguished by modality. In a self-limitation view, God possesses unilateral power but refrains for the sake of freedom or relationship. In Griffin-style process thought, such unilateral coercion is not a metaphysical possibility.

[ARGUMENT] The distinction changes responsibility. Voluntary restraint still permits the question, "Why did God not make an exception here?" Necessary non-coercion answers that no exception was available. It therefore gives process thought a cleaner innocence claim but a greater assurance problem. A God who voluntarily risks creation may remain sovereign; a process God participates in a field of distributed creativity.

[OBJECTION] Process thought may redefine divine power until God resembles one influential cause among others.

[REPLY] Hartshornean and process accounts distinguish supreme relational or persuasive power from finite power. God offers the best possibility to every occasion and perfectly receives all value; supremacy need not mean monopoly.

[QUALIFICATION] The answer must state that Whitehead's dipolar terminology, Hartshorne's critique of omnipotence and Griffin's theodicy are related but not interchangeable. Do not attribute every later theological conclusion directly to Whitehead.

[VERDICT] Process thought gives the most systematic non-classical response to natural evil, but its success depends on whether worship and hope require guaranteed control.

21. Karma: desert, causation and social ethics

[THESIS] Karma can be interpreted as desert, impersonal moral causation, character formation or bondage mechanics. The ethical evaluation changes with the interpretation.

[ARGUMENT] A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior wrongdoing. An impersonal-causation reading treats deeds as producing tendencies without a divine judge. A formative reading emphasizes how action shapes character and future possibility. Jain karmic matter gives a more literal bondage mechanism, while Buddhist dependent continuity denies a permanent owner. Nyaya adds an intelligent allocator;

Mimamsa can retain ritual efficacy without creatorhood.

[OBJECTION] Without memory, transparent proportionality or a stable person, retribution seems unfair. Beginninglessness avoids a first-cause regress only by denying a first temporal point; it does not show why the system is morally good. Socially, observers may infer desert from misfortune and withhold reform.

[REPLY] Memory is not the sole ground of responsibility even within one life, and causal continuity can support concern. More importantly, no school licenses a bystander to know a victim's hidden karmic history. Compassion, dana, ahimsa and assistance are themselves morally required actions.

[VERDICT] Use karma as a comparative model of trans-life moral causation, never as a warrant for explaining a particular victim. Its strongest feature is distribution; its greatest risk is retrospective moralization.

22. Advaita and the reality-status objection

[THESIS] Advaita changes the problem by distinguishing empirical experience from ultimate non-duality, but it cannot responsibly answer suffering with the slogan "the world is unreal."

[ARGUMENT] At the empirical level, persons, Isvara, karma, dharma, ignorance and suffering are operative. Knowledge removes the fundamental misidentification of self with finite body-mind and reveals non-dual Brahman. At the ultimate level, no independent evil principle confronts Brahman. The classical creator-versus-evil duality is therefore not final.

[OBJECTION] If empirical suffering is sublated, the view may appear to trivialize victims and make moral action provisional.

[REPLY] Empirical validity is sufficient for duties, compassion, discipline and liberation practice before realization. Sublatability does not mean non-occurrence at its operative level. Dream pain can be real to the dreamer without being ultimate, though this analogy must not be used pastorally to dismiss actual trauma.

[QUALIFICATION] Ramanuja's critique is relevant: if the world and selves are real modes dependent on Brahman, their suffering cannot be assigned merely a lower ontological status. Visistadvaita therefore retains a more direct theistic governance problem alongside karma and grace.

[VERDICT] Advaita dissolves the ultimate metaphysical dualism but leaves an empirical ethical and soteriological problem that must be answered through knowledge, duty and compassion.

23. Buddhist and Samkhya diagnoses compared

[THESIS] Buddhism and Samkhya both avoid a creator theodicy but disagree radically about self and the cause of bondage.

[ARGUMENT] Samkhya locates suffering in purusha's apparent identification with prakriti's evolutes. Discriminative knowledge separates consciousness from material-nature activity, culminating in kaivalya. Buddhism denies a permanent purusha and analyses dukkha through dependent origination, impermanence, craving and ignorance. Cessation is not isolation of a substantial witness but ending the conditions that sustain appropriation and suffering.

[OBJECTION] Removing God avoids culpability but may not explain why the beginningless causal order has its painful character. Samkhya must explain the conjunction of radically different principles; Buddhism must explain responsibility and continuity without self.

[REPLY] Both systems present the "why" as a mistaken demand for a first creator-cause and redirect attention to operative conditions and liberation. A causal diagnosis can be sufficient for practice even without a cosmic justification.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a reframing, not a victory by default. Existential pain, compassion and fairness remain, while the logical inconsistent triad disappears.

[VERDICT] Creatorless systems demonstrate that the problem of evil is not coextensive with the problem of suffering. They exchange theodicy for diagnosis and soteriology.

24. Protest, lament and moral knowledge

[THESIS] Protest is philosophically important because it treats the negative moral appearance of suffering as knowledge-bearing rather than as a defect of faith.

[ARGUMENT] Job's protest resists friends who infer guilt from suffering. Ivan Karamazov refuses to endorse a harmony that uses innocent agony. Camus makes solidarity and revolt an ethical answer without metaphysical reconciliation. These positions differ, but all reject the movement from "a total explanation may exist" to "the sufferer should accept our explanation."

[OBJECTION] Protest without metaphysical resolution may express emotion rather than answer the truth question.

[REPLY] Moral perception is part of the evidence. A theory that can preserve consistency only by erasing the prima facie wrongness of cruelty has changed the meaning of goodness. Protest also generates practical reasons to resist avoidable evil.

[QUALIFICATION] Anti-theodicy should not be represented as the claim that no meaning, redemption or religious response is possible. Its central objection is to comprehensive third-person justification and instrumentalization.

[VERDICT] Protest is not a logical refutation of theism, but it is a constraint on what may count as a morally adequate theodicy.

25. Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint

[THESIS] The order appropriate to an examination answer is not always the order appropriate at a hospital bed, disaster site or bereavement. Philosophical competence includes knowing when an explanation is morally mistimed.

[ARGUMENT] A sufferer may need safety, truthful presence, lament and practical assistance before causal or theological interpretation. Offering karma, punishment or soul-making as a diagnosis of a particular person's suffering exceeds available evidence and can add moral injury. Prayer can include protest; trust can coexist with uncertainty; religious communities can embody solidarity without claiming a hidden plan.

[OBJECTION] Refusing explanation may leave religious belief cognitively empty when it is most challenged.

[REPLY] Restraint is not permanent evasion. General philosophical accounts can be assessed in appropriate contexts. The immediate moral duty is not identical with the later intellectual task.

[QUALIFICATION] The same rule protects against secular triumphalism. One should not use a person's trauma as an occasion to score an atheistic conclusion either. Victim-centered reason asks what the evidence supports and what the situation ethically permits.

[VERDICT] The practical implication of the problem of evil is active compassion under epistemic humility. A theory that excuses preventable harm fails regardless of its abstract elegance.

26. Full comparative audit grid

Test	Freedom	Soul-making	Augustine	Leibniz	Process	Karma	Buddhism
Primary burden	Compati- bility	Actual purpose	Origin/statu- s	Optimal totality	Revised power	Distribution	Diagnosis
Moral evil	Strong	Moderate	Strong	Systemic	Distributed	Prior agency	Craving/action
Natural evil	Weak alone	Law/development	Punitive strain	Systemic	Stronger	Trans-life	Conditioned
Animal suffering	Weak	Weak	Severe strain	Aggregate risk	Included	Moralization risk	Included as dukkha
Victim focus	Indirect	At risk	Punitive	Aggregate	Solidarity	Blame risk	Compassion/p- ath
Afterlife role	Optional	Usually central	Judgement	Harmony	Uncertain	Rebirth/liberati- on	Rebirth/cessati- on
Attribute cost	None formally	Epistemic distance	Fall burden	Best-world claim	Omnipotence revised	Varies	No creator
Best use	Logical PYQ	Development comparison	2023 PYQ	Modal comparison	2025 PYQ	Indian parity	Reframing

[VERDICT] No theory dominates every axis. The examiner rewards explicit trade-offs: what class of evil is covered, what divine attribute is preserved, what moral cost arises and what residue remains.

27. Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God?

[THESIS] Evil first tests a concept of God and only then contributes evidence about whether any being answering to that concept exists. If "God" means an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good creator, apparently preventable suffering bears directly on the concept's instantiation. If God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

[ARGUMENT] The conceptual stage asks which attributes generate expectations. Perfect goodness creates an expectation of opposition to evil; knowledge creates awareness; power creates capacity; creatorhood creates responsibility for the framework. The evidential stage compares those expectations with the world. A process God predicts struggle and partial achievement more readily than classical control. Advaita predicts an empirically operative but ultimately sublatale order. Buddhism predicts conditioned suffering without a providential distribution. Each view must be tested against what it actually asserts.

[OBJECTION] This method lets believers escape evidence by revising God whenever a difficulty arises.

[REPLY] Revision is legitimate only if independently motivated and if its religious cost is paid openly. An ad hoc finite God introduced solely to avoid evil has weak explanatory value. Process thought, by contrast, offers a wider metaphysics of power and becoming, though that metaphysics is contestable.

[VERDICT] Evil does not address an empty word. It confirms or disconfirms profiles. The strongest answer therefore moves in the order **concept -> expectation -> evidence -> revision cost**.

28. Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering?

[THESIS] Some virtue logically requires vulnerability, but it does not follow that the actual quantity and distribution of suffering is required.

[ARGUMENT] Courage needs perceived danger, compassion needs another's need, forgiveness presupposes wrong, and responsibility needs consequential action. These are relation-dependent goods. A world containing them cannot be wholly insulated from harm. Yet virtues differ: creativity, friendship, gratitude and understanding do not require atrocity. Even danger-dependent virtues may require only bounded challenge. The critic can therefore grant soul-making while denying that horrors are necessary.

[OBJECTION] The total network of virtues, histories and free relations may require risks that no local observer can calculate.

[REPLY] This possibility creates humility but not justification. The theist should avoid the universal claim that every evil is necessary and defend only a general risk structure. Adams's defeat condition must handle cases that exceed ordinary formation.

[QUALIFICATION] The question "Could God create virtue directly?" also concerns authenticity. Implanted dispositions may be good qualities, but achieved virtues include a person's authorship and history. That distinction supports development without proving every route to development morally permissible.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains why a frictionless world may lack important goods; proportionality and goodness-to-persons decide whether the explanation reaches actual horrors.

29. Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation?

[THESIS] Permission and causation are not identical, but a creator's permission can still carry responsibility where prevention is easy, knowledge complete and the stakes grave.

[ARGUMENT] A human wrongdoer can be the direct efficient cause of moral evil. God, on classical theism, causes the agent and sustaining order but does not determine the free choice. This supports derivative creaturely culpability. Nevertheless, knowingly selecting and sustaining a world creates a responsibility of framework and permission. Moral analysis therefore needs at least three levels: authorship of the act, design of available powers and consequences, and decision whether to intervene.

[OBJECTION] If God intervened whenever misuse became serious, creaturely action would not be real.

[REPLY] Responsibility does not require unlimited consequence. Legal and social systems constrain harm while retaining agency. The theist must identify why divine restraint is more limited than responsible human restraint should be.

[QUALIFICATION] Process thought changes the third level by denying unilateral prevention. Karma systems distribute responsibility across a life-series. Non-creator systems remove framework selection by God but retain causal questions about bondage.

[VERDICT] The 2022 PYQ is best answered through layered rather than exclusive responsibility: human authorship can be real while divine permission remains philosophically assessable.

30. Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy?

[THESIS] Eschatology can prevent a life from being finally defeated by evil, but future bliss is not automatically a moral warrant for earlier permission.

[ARGUMENT] Hick needs eventual fulfilment because earthly opportunities are radically unequal. Adams needs a good powerful enough to defeat horrors within the participant's life. Augustine's judgement framework seeks cosmic moral order. These uses differ: completion of development, personal redemption and retributive balance are not interchangeable.

[OBJECTION] If eternal good infinitely exceeds finite suffering, the total life is good.

[REPLY] Aggregate outweighing does not settle consent, use and dignity. It would be wrong to harm a person deliberately merely because one later supplies a larger benefit. The theist needs an internal relation between redemption and the suffered evil, or a reason why permission respected the person throughout.

[QUALIFICATION] Eschatology is a substantive religious commitment, not publicly established by the problem of evil itself. It may belong in a cumulative theology, but should be labelled rather than smuggled into a supposedly neutral proof.

[VERDICT] Eschatology is strongest as a theory of defeat and hope, weaker as a retroactive licence. It deepens the response only when it remains victim-centered.

31. Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem?

[THESIS] Petitionary prayer can intensify evil's evidential problem because traditions portray God as able and willing to respond, while many urgent petitions appear unanswered. It can also transform the existential response through lament, solidarity and moral mobilization.

[ARGUMENT] If God sometimes prevents harm in response to prayer, selective non-prevention demands an account of distribution. If God never changes outcomes, petition requires reinterpretation. Stable-law defenders may say prayer is not a mechanism for suspending causation; it can align the agent with divine purpose and community action. Protest prayer preserves relationship without pretending to understand permission.

[OBJECTION] Unanswered prayer is merely another instance of limited human perspective.

[REPLY] That answer is available but costly. It makes claims of answered providence harder to interpret and can render petitionary expectations opaque. A consistent view must treat positive and negative cases with the same epistemic standard.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a bounded link to religious experience, reason and faith. The Problem of Evil owner uses prayer only to test lived implications, not to provide a full theory of prayer.

[VERDICT] Prayer does not solve evil. At its best it refuses isolation, voices protest and generates compassionate action without claiming privileged knowledge of hidden reasons.

32. Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness

[THESIS] Hiddenness aggravates suffering when a loving God could provide unmistakable presence, guidance or consolation without removing all freedom.

[ARGUMENT] Hick values epistemic distance because overwhelming awareness might compromise free relationship and development. The critic distinguishes coercive display from adequate availability: a parent can remain non-coercive while being recognizably present to a terrified child. Sincere nonbelief and divine silence during horror therefore add an interpersonal dimension to evidential evil.

[OBJECTION] Religious growth may require trust under ambiguity, and divine presence may occur in forms the sufferer cannot presently recognize.

[REPLY] Again, possibility is not proportionality. Some ambiguity may preserve freedom; extreme absence may destroy the very trust and agency soul-making requires. The distribution of religious awareness becomes relevant.

[QUALIFICATION] Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is itself always evil. Use it as an auxiliary pressure on epistemic-distance explanations.

[VERDICT] Hiddenness shows that the problem concerns not only prevention of pain but the quality of divine relationship under pain.

33. Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions?

[THESIS] Non-theistic traditions cannot be imported as ready-made theodicies, but they can correct theism's tendency to prioritize cosmic justification over diagnosis and practice.

[ARGUMENT] Buddhism starts from dukkha, traces conditions and prescribes a path. Jainism links bondage to disciplined non-violence. Samkhya diagnoses misidentification and seeks discriminative release. These approaches ask what sustains suffering and how agency can respond, without first vindicating a creator. Theistic traditions can likewise make lament, compassion and prevention central even while retaining questions of providence.

[OBJECTION] Borrowing practice while retaining creator belief avoids the distinctive metaphysical challenge.

[REPLY] The challenge remains; learning at the practical level is not a logical solution. It is a test of whether a proposed belief produces responsible action. Comparative philosophy need not erase doctrinal difference to identify shared ethical insight.

[QUALIFICATION] Karma should not be treated as the universal bridge. Buddhist no-self, Jaina jiva, Samkhya purusha and Vedantic selves differ fundamentally.

[VERDICT] The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a permission problem; non-creator systems supply alternative causal and soteriological grammars; each can be evaluated for compassion, responsibility and explanatory cost.

34. Essay laboratory - Final position options

[THESIS] A candidate need not claim a total solution. A reasoned final position can take one of four forms, provided its cost is explicit.

1. **Classical preservation:** Free will, stable law, soul-making and eschatological defeat jointly make theism coherent and not unreasonable. Cost: multiple auxiliary commitments and a residue of apparently gratuitous evil.

2. **Epistemically modest preservation:** Plantinga defeats contradiction; skeptical theism blocks overconfident induction; no complete theodicy is claimed. Cost: opacity of goodness and providence.

3. **Non-classical revision:** Process or finite theism reduces culpability through distributed power. Cost: weakened sovereignty and assurance.

4. **Non-theistic reframing:** Buddhism, Jainism or Samkhya removes the creator defendant and prioritizes diagnosis and liberation. Cost: unresolved questions of causal order, identity or ultimate why.

[ARGUMENT] These are not equal answers to one fixed question. Each changes premises, explanatory burdens and religious practices. The examiner should be shown exactly what has been preserved, revised or abandoned.

[VERDICT] The most defensible synthetic judgement is that strict logical incompatibility is not established, evidential evil remains substantial, and moral protest limits every universal theodicy. Philosophical integrity requires continued action against suffering rather than premature closure.

Solved Conceptual Drills and Distinction Loops

Drill 1 - Defence or theodicy?

Prompt: Plantinga says it is possible that every feasible world with significant freedom contains wrongdoing.

Answer: Defence. It blocks logical contradiction by possibility and does not claim to identify God's actual reason for this world's history.

Drill 2 - Explanation or justification?

Prompt: Tectonic movement explains earthquakes.

Answer: Causal explanation only. It does not show why an omnipotent good creator permits that law-system or this distribution of harm.

Drill 3 - Privation or illusion?

Prompt: Augustine says blindness is a privation.

Answer: The loss is real in a subject; evil is not a rival substance. "Privation" must never be glossed as "imaginary."

Drill 4 - Karma or fatalism?

Prompt: Present conditions have karmic causes.

Answer: This does not entail that present action is powerless. Most karmic systems retain new action, ethical discipline and liberation. Nor may observers infer a victim's specific guilt.

Drill 5 - Skeptical theism or positive theodicy?

Prompt: We cannot expect to know God's reasons, and we know the reason is soul-making.

Answer: The pair is in tension. A bounded skeptical defence may coexist with modest local claims, but confident global ignorance and confident global theodicy cannot both control the same paragraph.

Seven Verified UPSC PYQs - Examiner-Grade Models

2019 Q6(b) - 15 marks

Exact verified question

What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion?

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 15 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] Evil and the profane can provide a structural foundation for religion by defining the predicament to be overcome and the boundary separating ordinary life from sacred order; however, profane does not mean evil, and religion also arises from wonder, gratitude and encounter.

[ARGUMENT] Durkheim's sacred-profane distinction is classificatory: sacred things are set apart and protected, while the profane is the ordinary sphere. Beliefs and rites concerning sacred things unify a moral community. The contrast supplies boundaries, taboos, institutions and ritual transitions. Otto's holy as numinous and Eliade's analyses of hierophany further show how sacred space and time gain salience against ordinary homogeneity.

Evil performs a different foundational role. Sin, impurity, suffering, ignorance or bondage supplies a diagnosis; religion then offers purification, reconciliation, liberation or salvation. Buddhism begins with dukkha and proceeds through cause, cessation and path. Jainism links influx and bondage to purification. Advaita diagnoses avidya and misidentification. These cases show that the founding negative is not always moral wickedness.

[OBJECTION] Reducing religion to management of fear, evil or pollution ignores celebration, love, awe and gratitude. It can also confuse sociological function with truth.

[REPLY] "Foundation" need not mean sole origin or proof of truth. Evil and profane provide a structural problem and boundary through which practices become intelligible.

[VERDICT] They found religion functionally - predicament plus sacred boundary - but do not by themselves establish theism or exhaust religious life.

Why this earns marks: It separates evil from profane, uses Durkheim, Otto/Eliade and Indian soteriologies, answers the functional directive, adds a limitation and closes with a precise verdict.

2020 Q6(b) - 15 marks

Exact verified question

What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss.

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 15 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] The logical problem alleges inconsistency among an omnipotent God, a wholly good God and the existence of evil. The inconsistency arises only with bridge premises about what goodness would eliminate and what power can actualize.

[ARGUMENT] (1) God is omnipotent. (2) God is wholly good. (3) Evil exists. (4) A wholly good being eliminates every evil it can. (5) An omnipotent being can eliminate every evil. Therefore evil should not exist. Mackie argued that theism must surrender or qualify at least one proposition.

The theist replies by restricting the bridges. Omnipotence is power over the logically possible, not power to determine an act while leaving it libertarianly free. Plantinga's Free Will Defence proposes that significant freedom is a great good and that it is possible every feasible world with such freedom includes wrongdoing. Transworld depravity names this modal possibility; it does not mean universal constant wickedness.

[OBJECTION] The defence is weaker on natural evil and does not show why this world's scale of suffering is needed.

[REPLY] Those points transform the deductive problem into an evidential one. A logical defence needs compatibility, not a complete history.

[VERDICT] Plantinga substantially answers the strict contradiction, but Rowe-style evidential evil, animal suffering and horrendous evils preserve the larger challenge.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs premises, identifies bridge principles, states Plantinga accurately, separates logical from evidential burden and offers a graded conclusion.

2021 Q5(e) - 10 marks

Exact verified question

Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil.

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 10 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] Evil creates an omnipotence paradox because an unlimitedly powerful creator appears able to prevent evil, while perfect goodness appears to require prevention. The paradox weakens once omnipotence is defined as power to do the logically possible and morally coherent, but an evidential residue remains.

[ARGUMENT] If God creates and sustains everything, knows every consequence and can prevent every harm, permission appears imputable to God. Yet power does not include contradictions. God cannot causally determine a choice and make it libertarianly free in the same respect. Plantinga therefore argues that a world with significant freedom may be infeasible without risk of wrongdoing.

[OBJECTION] God could prevent natural evil or excessive consequences without determining choices. Moreover, an omnipotent God could create free agents who always freely choose good.

[REPLY] The free-will defender distinguishes a logically describable world from a feasible world given creaturely counterfactuals. Stable-law and soul-making approaches supplement natural evil, but they do not clearly justify excess.

[VERDICT] The paradox does not prove omnipotence incoherent; it forces a distinction between logical power and unilateral control. It remains evidentially serious where suffering is unrelated to freedom.

Why this earns marks: It directly connects omnipotence to evil, uses the logical-possibility restriction, gives the strongest objection and avoids claiming that freedom solves natural evil.

2022 Q6(c) - 15 marks

Exact verified question

If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine.

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 15 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] Absolute creatorhood makes God causally responsible for the existence and powers of agents, but it does not automatically erase derivative human responsibility. The issue is whether creaturely agency is genuine and whether God's permission is morally justified.

[ARGUMENT] The critic argues: God knowingly creates each agent, circumstance and consequence; therefore the ultimate explanatory chain ends in God. If God could actualize a better world, shifting all blame to creatures is incomplete. Augustine's claim that evil originates in defective will and Plantinga's significant freedom reply by distinguishing primary creation from secondary self-determination. Causing a free agent to exist is not identical with causing the agent's wrongful choice.

[OBJECTION] God selected the world knowing the misuse and could limit consequences. Natural evil is not traceable to human choice.

[REPLY] Freedom may require non-control over choice, and stable law may require real consequences. Yet these claims establish at most a possible permission; they do not excuse every excess. Process thought instead limits unilateral divine power, while non-creator Indian systems remove the creator defendant.

[VERDICT] Responsibility is layered: humans can be culpable for freely chosen moral evil, while classical theism retains a burden regarding creation, permission, natural evil and world-selection.

Why this earns marks: It refuses the false choice between divine and human responsibility, distinguishes causal levels, uses Augustine/Plantinga/process comparison and gives a qualified judgement.

2023 Q8(a) - 20 marks

Exact verified question

"All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 20 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] Augustine's statement combines a moral genealogy of evil with a punitive account: culpable evil is sin, while suffered evil is punishment. Its privation and free-will elements are philosophically important, but the universal punitive formula is inadequate for innocent, animal and evolutionary suffering.

[ARGUMENT] Augustine holds that being as such is good because created by a good God. Evil is *privatio boni* - the corruption or absence of a due perfection - rather than a substance created by God. Moral evil begins when finite will turns from the highest good toward lesser goods. In the larger fall narrative, natural disorder and suffering follow sin, allowing Augustine to clear God of creating evil.

[STRENGTH] Privation defeats dualism and accurately describes many evils as parasitic on goods: blindness presupposes an eye, betrayal a relationship, corruption an ordered capacity. Free will locates culpability in agents.

[OBJECTION] A perfect creation's uncaused fall is difficult; an omniscient creator foreknows the result. Geological and evolutionary suffering precedes human agency. Punishment of descendants or animals violates proportionality, and eternal punishment would perpetuate rather than defeat evil.

[REPLY] Privation need not deny the reality of pain, and fall may be read as a structural account of creaturely defect rather than a scientific history. But this revision retreats from the literal universal punishment thesis.

[COMPARISON] Hick replaces retribution with development; process thought revises power; karma explains distribution but risks victim blame.

[VERDICT] "Sin or punishment" illuminates moral disorder within an Augustinian system but cannot serve as a complete theodicy for the actual history of suffering.

Why this earns marks: It explicates both privation and punishment, uses the blindness example, integrates modern evolutionary criticism, compares alternatives and gives a directive-responsive verdict.

2024 Q6(c) - 15 marks

Exact verified question

"The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 15 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] The problem of evil is directly concept-dependent: it is most acute where God is an omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good creator and sustainer. Altering creatorhood, power, knowledge, goodness or world-relation changes or dissolves the formal contradiction, though suffering remains.

[ARGUMENT] Classical theism generates Mackie's triad because perfect goodness opposes evil, omnipotence can prevent it, omniscience knows it and creatorhood appears to make permission attributable. Free-will, soul-making and law-order responses try to preserve the profile by supplying morally sufficient reasons.

Process theism revises omnipotence: God persuades but cannot coerce finite actualities, buying innocence at the cost of sovereignty. Open theism revises the settled status of future free acts. A finite God faces struggle rather than culpable permission. Advaita locates evil within the empirical order of avidya and karma while ultimate non-duality alters the God-world dualism. Buddhism, Samkhya, Mimamsa and Jainism lack an omnipotent creator defendant, so the question becomes diagnosis of dukkha or bondage. Nyaya and Visistadvaita retain a divine governor and therefore must relate karma to just administration.

[OBJECTION] Concept-dependence may appear to solve the problem by definition, and impersonal or non-creator systems still face suffering, justice and consolation.

[REPLY] The claim is not that suffering vanishes, but that the logical accusation changes with the metaphysical defendant.

[VERDICT] Evil is a stress-test of a God-concept, not a uniform refutation of religion. Revising the concept dissolves one problem while relocating costs to worship-worthiness, providence or karmic justice.

Why this earns marks: It makes the God-concept the organizing axis, compares preserved and revised attributes, includes accurate Indian diversity and avoids saying non-theism eliminates suffering.

2025 Q6(b) - 15 marks

Exact verified question

Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil.

Demand decoding

The directive requires a direct thesis, the argument or doctrine in structured form, its strongest objection, the strongest available reply, a residual qualification and a judgement proportional to 15 marks.

Model answer

[THESIS] Process theodicy explains evil by rejecting classical unilateral omnipotence. God is perfectly persuasive and receptive but cannot wholly determine finite actualities, so evil does not arise from a preventable divine decree.

[ARGUMENT] In Whitehead's process metaphysics, reality is composed of becoming actual occasions with some self-determination; creativity and power are distributed. God's primordial nature orders possibilities and supplies each occasion an initial aim, while the consequent nature receives and preserves the world's achievements and suffering. Because finite occasions partly create themselves, divine action is persuasive lure rather than coercion. Evil occurs through discord, collision and failure to realize better possibilities.

Hartshorne argues that monopolistic omnipotence is incoherent if other beings are genuinely actual. Griffin develops the crucial theodicy: persuasion is a metaphysical necessity, not a voluntary self-limitation. Cobb provides theological systematization. Divine solidarity is expressed in the process image of God as fellow-sufferer.

[STRENGTH] The view directly addresses natural as well as moral evil and avoids blaming every victim or choice.

[OBJECTION] A non-coercive God may be unworthy of worship, unable to guarantee final victory, and dependent on a contested metaphysics.

[REPLY] Process thinkers answer that relational power and faithful persuasion are more coherent and morally admirable than total control.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy purchases divine innocence and solidarity by revising sovereignty. Its adequacy depends on whether persuasive power is enough for worship and hope.

Why this earns marks: It names distinct process thinkers, explains primordial/consequent nature, initial aim and necessary persuasion, and states the exact theological trade-off.

Solved Original Mains Practice

10 marks - Distinguish a defence from a theodicy

Question: Distinguish philosophical defence from theodicy in the problem of evil. Why does the distinction matter?

Model solution

[THESIS] A defence supplies a logically possible reason showing compatibility between God and evil; a theodicy claims the actual or probable divine reason. Plantinga's freedom proposal is primarily a defence, whereas Hick's developmental account and process thought are theodicies.

[ARGUMENT] The distinction controls evidential burden. To answer Mackie's contradiction, the theist need not prove what God actually intends. To explain Rowe's evidence or pastorally interpret suffering, mere possibility is insufficient. Conversely, criticizing Plantinga for not explaining each disaster mistakes his target.

[OBJECTION] A merely possible story may be too weak to matter religiously.

[REPLY] It matters logically but leaves probability and meaning open.

[VERDICT] The distinction prevents both overclaiming and unfair criticism.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms, names examples, connects each to a different burden and closes with exam utility.

15 marks - Animal suffering

Question: Does animal suffering defeat the major theodicies? Discuss.

Model solution

[THESIS] Animal suffering does not deductively defeat every theism, but it sharply weakens freedom, punishment and anthropocentric soul-making accounts.

[ARGUMENT] Pre-human predation, disease and extinction cannot be products of human misuse. Stable-law and evolutionary accounts explain how sentient life develops through regular processes, but mechanism is not justification. Hickian growth applies weakly where creatures lack reflective moral agency. Process thought better explains lack of prevention by limiting coercive power, but sacrifices classical omnipotence. Karmic accounts extend responsibility across forms of life, yet risk opaque desert and victim blame.

[OBJECTION] A fecund autonomous creation may require evolutionary risk.

[REPLY] This may explain some vulnerability, not every intensity or duration. A morally adequate account must include animals within final goodness rather than use them for human goods.

[VERDICT] Animal suffering converts the debate from abstract compatibility into comparative evidential cost.

Why this earns marks: It uses evolutionary evidence as philosophical pressure, tests several theories and gives a graded rather than absolute verdict.

20 marks - Can skeptical theism and soul-making be combined?

Question: Critically examine whether skeptical theism can be consistently combined with a soul-making theodicy.

Model solution

[THESIS] They can be combined only asymmetrically: modest confidence about some developmental goods may coexist with humility about the full providential order, but global claims of ignorance and global claims of known purpose are inconsistent.

[ARGUMENT] Skeptical theism undercuts Rowe's noseeum inference by denying representative access to divine goods and entailments. Soul-making positively claims that epistemic distance, stable law and hardship form virtue. If humans cannot expect to know relevant divine reasons, confident assertion that suffering exists for soul-making exceeds the skeptical premise.

[OBJECTION] The views address different levels: one rebuts an inference, the other offers a partial account.

[REPLY] That restricted combination is coherent if soul-making is presented as explaining some classes of hardship rather than every evil. Horrendous and animal suffering remain outside its secure range.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] Even bounded skepticism risks weakening trust in moral appearances.

[REPLY] Restrict it to global divine-governance inference while retaining local duties to prevent suffering.

[VERDICT] A disciplined hybrid is possible, but it must renounce total theodicy and preserve moral action.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the second-order consistency issue, provides objection, reply and counter-reply, and states exact conditions for a coherent synthesis.

Solved Topic-Specific MCQs

1. Plantinga's Free Will Defence primarily aims to establish:

- A. the logical compatibility of God and moral evil B. the actual historical cause of every evil C. the probability of Christian revelation D. the unreality of suffering

Answer: A. A defence needs a possible compatibility story, not a complete theodicy.

2. Rowe's fawn case is best classified as:

- A. a paradox of omnipotence B. an evidential case of apparently gratuitous suffering C. a proof of natural-law determinism D. an Augustinian punishment account

Answer: B. Its force is inductive and probabilistic, not deductive.

3. Which claim most accurately states transworld depravity?

- A. Every person performs evil in every possible world B. God causes every creaturely defect C. It is possible that every feasible world with significantly free creatures includes some wrongdoing by each relevant creaturely essence D. Natural evil is caused by human freedom

Answer: C. It is a technical feasibility possibility, not universal maximal wickedness.

4. The central cost of process theodicy is:

- A. denial of all divine goodness B. denial of creaturely agency C. denial of natural regularity D. revision of classical unilateral omnipotence

Answer: D. Process thought distributes power and treats divine action as persuasive.

5. Augustine's privation theory means:

- A. evil is a corruption or absence of a due good, not a rival substance B. evil is merely imaginary C. pain is always deserved punishment D. matter is intrinsically evil

Answer: A. Privation does not deny the reality of experienced loss.

6. Skeptical theism directly challenges:

- A. the existence of natural laws B. the inference from no visible divine reason to probably no divine reason C. libertarian freedom D. the distinction between moral and natural evil

Answer: B. It targets human epistemic access to God's reasons.

7. In Adams's discussion, defeat of a horrendous evil is stronger than:

A. divine foreknowledge B. causal explanation C. merely balancing it with unrelated goods D. creaturely freedom

Answer: C. Defeat must address goodness within the sufferer's life.

8. Which statement best distinguishes Buddhism from classical theodicy?

A. Buddhism denies suffering B. Buddhism makes a creator distribute karma C. Buddhism treats evil as a substance
D. Buddhism diagnoses conditioned dukkha without defending an omnipotent creator

Answer: D. It reframes the problem rather than solving the creator's permission problem.

9. A law-governed-order account most directly explains:

A. why regular causal consequences are required for agency and responsibility B. why every actual degree of suffering is necessary C. why victims deserve harm D. why God lacks knowledge

Answer: A. Regularity is a necessary-condition argument, not a total justification.

10. Which pair is in greatest methodological tension?

A. moral evil and free will B. global skeptical theism and confident total theodicy C. process power and persuasion D. Buddhism and non-creatorhood

Answer: B. One says we cannot know the reasons; the other says we know them comprehensively.

11. The strongest philosophical objection to crude karmic explanation is:

A. it always requires a creator B. it denies moral causation C. it can encourage victim blame while leaving identity and proportionality obscure D. it makes liberation impossible

Answer: C. School differences and compassion duties must be stated.

12. The 2024 concept-dependence thesis implies:

A. suffering is unreal outside theism B. all religions share the same problem C. only moral evil matters D. changing the divine profile changes the formal problem but may relocate other costs

Answer: D. Non-classical and non-creator systems face different burdens.

Remedial Loop

Confusion 1 - "Possible" means "plausible"

Correction: A logically possible freedom story defeats contradiction but may remain evidentially improbable. Always state the level.

Confusion 2 - "Privation" means "unreal"

Correction: A real subject can lack a due good and suffer that lack. Privation is an ontological dependency claim.

Confusion 3 - "Karma is the Indian answer"

Correction: Nyaya, Mimamsa, Advaita, Visistadvaita, Samkhya, Buddhism and Jainism disagree about creator, self, mechanism and liberation.

Confusion 4 - "Process God voluntarily chooses not to intervene"

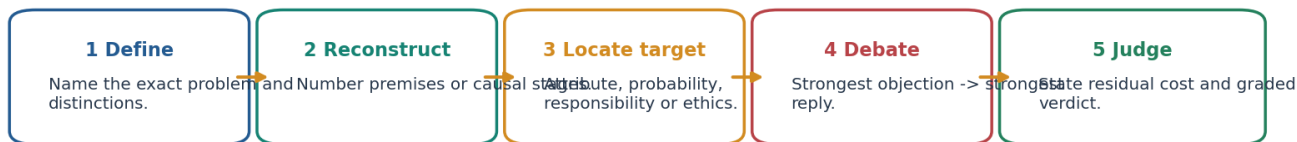
Correction: Griffin-style process theodicy treats coercion as metaphysically unavailable, unlike voluntary self-limitation.

Confusion 5 - "Skeptical theism proves a hidden reason"

Correction: It undercuts an inference; it does not identify or prove the reason.

Final Consolidated Register Notes - Problem of Evil

Philosophy Optional answer spine



Evidence rule

Claim -> named thinker/text/example -> what it proves -> limitation. Add Indian comparison only when it changes the argument.

For 20 marks, add a counter-reply and compare preservation versus revision of divine attributes.

Philosophy answer spine

A. Argument forms at a glance

- **Logical:** omni-power + perfect goodness + evil + unrestricted bridge premises -> inconsistency.
- **Plantinga reply:** significant freedom and feasible-world limits make compatibility possible.
- **Evidential:** apparently gratuitous suffering probably exists -> perfect theism probably false.
- **Rowe pressure:** fawn; no visible greater good or prevented worse evil.
- **Skeptical-theist reply:** limited access weakens noseem inference; bound it to avoid moral skepticism.
- **Existential:** asks how trust and meaning survive.
- **Anti-theodicy:** asks whether comprehensive justification wrongs victims.

B. Distinctions that earn marks

Do not collapse	Precise distinction
Defence / theodicy	Possible compatibility / actual-probable divine reason
Explanation / justification	Cause or mechanism / moral permissibility
Compatibility / probability	No contradiction / evidential expectation
Moral / natural / metaphysical evil	Wrong agency / non-voluntary harm / finitude
Suffering / wrongdoing	Experienced harm / culpable action
Compensation / defeat	Later good / evil integrated within sufferer's good
Privation / illusion	Dependent lack / unreality
Humility / paralysis	Limited knowledge / refusal of moral action

C. Western response bank

- **Augustine:** being is good; evil is privation; defective will; fall/punishment. Strong on anti-dualism, weak on evolutionary and innocent suffering.
- **Plantinga:** logical defence; significant freedom; possible transworld depravity. Strong on moral compatibility, weak as total explanation.
- **Hick:** image-to-likeness development; epistemic distance; stable risky world; eschatological completion. Strong on growth, weak on horrors and animals.
- **Leibniz:** best compossible totality. Strong on systemic trade-offs, weak on victim-centered justification.
- **Law order:** regularity enables knowledge and agency. Necessary-condition insight, not proof of every excess.
- **Process:** distributed power, initial aim, persuasive God, consequent reception. Innocence and solidarity bought by revised sovereignty.
- **Skeptical theism:** epistemic undercutting; use modestly.
- **Adams:** horrendous evil, goodness-to-persons, defeat rather than balancing-off.
- **Protest:** Job, Ivan, Camus and post-Holocaust caution expose moral limits of explanation.

D. Indian comparison bank

- **Nyaya:** theistic karmic administration; still faces painful-mechanism question.
- **Mimamsa:** non-creator karmic efficacy through action and apurva.
- **Advaita:** avidya, karma and empirical suffering under ultimate non-duality; never call empirical pain simply unreal.
- **Visistadvaita/Dvaita:** real world, personal God, agency, karma and grace; do not merge with Advaita.
- **Samkhya:** creatorless bondage through purusha-prakrti misidentification; liberation by discrimination.
- **Buddhism:** dukkha, dependent origination, cessation and path; reframes rather than theodicies.
- **Jainism:** karmic matter, jiva, influx/bondage/stoppage/shedding, ahimsa and self-effort.
- **Karma critique:** victim blame, regress, identity, memory, proportionality and social legitimation.

E. Hard-case checklist

1. Pre-human and animal suffering.
2. Horrendous evils that destroy agency.
3. Unequal distribution and epistemic opportunity.
4. Free will in heaven.
5. Selective intervention within stable laws.
6. Hiddenness to sincere sufferers.
7. Compensation versus justification.
8. Whether revision leaves a worship-worthy God.

F. Seven PYQ routes

- **2019:** sacred/profane boundary plus evil as soteriological predicament; profane is not evil.
- **2020:** triad, bridges, Plantinga, logical/evidential distinction.
- **2021:** logically possible power, freedom, natural-evil residue.
- **2022:** layered responsibility: creator, permission and derivative agency.
- **2023:** privation + free will + punishment; evolutionary and innocent-suffering critique.
- **2024:** organize by God-concept; preserve versus revise versus remove creator.
- **2025:** process metaphysics, initial aim, persuasive necessity, solidarity and sovereignty cost.

G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines

10 marks:

Define exact problem -> reconstruct 3-4 premises -> one objection/reply -> verdict.

15 marks:

Direct thesis -> distinctions -> named argument -> strongest objection -> strongest reply -> one comparison -> residual cost -> verdict.

20 marks:

Conceptual map -> formal/causal reconstruction -> two levels of criticism -> reply and counter-reply -> Indian/Western comparison -> victim-centered ethical test -> graded judgement.

H. Final judgement ladder

1. **Too strong:** "Evil disproves every God and every religion."
2. **Too weak:** "Free will completely solves evil."
3. **Better:** Plantinga defeats a simple contradiction but not evidential or existential evil.
4. **Strong:** Different theodicies explain different classes of evil while carrying distinct costs.
5. **Best:** The problem is concept-dependent yet irreducibly evidential and moral; no response is adequate unless it states its burden, treats animals and horrors seriously, avoids victim blame, and strengthens compassionate action.

[MEMORY] **D-R-O-R-V** - Define, Reconstruct, Objection, Reply, Verdict.

End state: The candidate should be able to formalize the logical and evidential arguments, compare preservation and revision strategies, distinguish Indian schools, answer all seven verified PYQs and refuse both facile optimism and facile dismissal.

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